THE PUNISHING

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Pink Script

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FADE IN: *

1 EXT. FERRY - DAY 1

Crossing a misty CHANNEL. A somberness to the vessel's steady glide. The only passengers onboard.

The coastline of REYKJAVIK, ICELAND disappears into the background as the ferry crosses dark, calm waters.

GWEN LAWSON and PETER LAWSON stand at the bow-side railing. Their eyes ahead, their shoulders touching. Lost in thought as the warm, summertime breeze passes between them.

Both are in their late thirties, though Peter's unmissable enervation adds years to his appearance. His tightly-shorn hair certainly adds a curiosity.

Glimmers of hope push through Gwen's musing gaze as a remote ISLAND manifests ahead. Its jagged, volcanic cliffs tumble to the ocean in breathtaking swaths of black and green.

She looks at Peter, reassuringly places her hand on top of his. When she does, WE SEE the word "JOY" tattooed on her wrist. Peter regards it for a moment...

Then he meets Gwen's hopeful gaze with a muted smile.

2 EXT. FERRY - DAY 2

The ferry has pulled into port. Summer brings warmer temperatures and welcome bouts of sunshine.

Gwen and Peter approach a simple TAXI STAND, where an older-model vehicle sits waiting. No real expectation anyone will want or need a ride that day.

Before getting into the vehicle, Gwen stops for a moment to take in the desolate shoreline...

The waves shattering against the rocks...

And, weighing anchor just offshore in his small boat, a handsome LOCAL MAN in his late 30s wearing a YELLOW PARKA.

She and Peter climb into the back of the TAXI.

3 EXT. ROAD - DAY 3

The taxi traverses a lonely, Edenic road.

Towering mountains and verdant, wildflower-smothered hillsides. Meltwater cascades down to rivers and streams.

Very few houses and/or people in sight. The island's deep, beautiful isolation coming into relief.

4 INT. TAXI - SAME 4

Gwen quietly regards the vast, unspoiled surroundings as they roll by. Peter's mind is elsewhere. The ICELANDIC TAXI DRIVER sits silently behind the wheel.

GWEN
I didn't realize it was so green here.

PETER
Iceland's green, and Greenland's full of ice.

GWEN
(vaguely familiar)
Was that Churchill?

PETER
D2. Mighty Ducks.

They share a chortle, which leads Peter to cough a few times.

GWEN
You okay?

PETER
Little tired.

GWEN
We'll be there soon. I think.

Gwen checks her phone, trying to pull up GPS. "NO SERVICE."

GWEN (CONT'D)
You have any signal?

PETER
(checks his phone)
Nothing.

Gwen reaches into her purse. Retrieves a printout of an email sent to her. Gives it a cursory glance.

GWEN
She said to just stay on this road.

PETER
How did you find this lady, again?

GWEN
She found me. On some message board I'd posted on. I've told you all this already.

PETER
I know, but... What if she's scamming us?

Peter coughs. Deep, hacking. Gwen hands him tissues from her purse. Rubs his back.

He coughs into the tissues. Sees specks of blood.

Neither he nor Gwen seems particularly surprised by this.

PETER (CONT'D)
(re: tissue/cough)
At least there wasn't any snot in it this time.

GWEN
See? Things are getting better already.

They both smirk ruefully.

4A EXT. FARMHOUSE - DRIVEWAY - DAY 4A

A long, dirt-path driveway leads to the road. After a beat, the taxi arrives, turning onto the property.

The taxi PASSES CAMERA, and WE REVEAL a lonely dwelling sitting atop an empty expanse, crowned by lush hills. Its solitude gives way to an alluring beauty.

4B EXT. FARMHOUSE - DRIVEWAY - MOMENTS LATER 4B

The taxi reaches a ramshackle metal livestock gate, dangling on its rusty hinges.

This is apparently as far as the vehicle will go.

5 INT. FARMHOUSE - SAME 5

Through an upstairs window, WE SEE the taxi far down the driveway, idling at the livestock gate. *

6 INT. TAXI - SAME 6

Gwen and Peter stare up at the house, far ahead. Bemused.

PETER
This is it?

GWEN
I guess.

Gwen's starting to wonder if he's having second thoughts.

GWEN (CONT'D)
You trust me, don't you?

Peter looks at Gwen, then back up at the house. Letting hope shine through his creeping shadow of doubt.

He gets out. Gwen takes a moment, then climbs out as well.

7 EXT. FARMHOUSE - DAY 7

A vegetable GARDEN and livestock BARN. Clothes and bedsheets hang from a laundry line, snapping in the summer breeze.

Gwen and Peter trek up the hillside, toward the farmhouse.

Peter's steps are labored, his breaths ragged. The extent of his debilitation becoming apparent, marked most starkly by the LESIONS peeking from the back of his shirt collar.

Drawing closer, Peter sees a tired-eyed, 60-something-year-old ICELANDIC MAN chopping wood by the barn. Some labor behind each swing. He stops when he notices them.

Gwen meanwhile lines up a quick landscape photo on her phone.

PETER
Gwen...

GWEN
Just one quick one. It's like a fairytale around here.

As she does, an ICELANDIC WOMAN around the man's age exits from the house. The woman finishes putting on a shawl, as if caught a bit unawares. This is INGA OLAFSSON.

INGA
(accented English)
May I help you?

GWEN
Hi, are you Inga?

INGA
Yes.

GWEN
I'm Gwen Lawson. This is my husband Peter.
(smiles)
We're here.

Inga turns and looks to the Icelandic Man. Nods subtly to him. We'll come to know him as her husband, JON OLAFSSON.

INGA
I was expecting you tomorrow. If at all.

GWEN
We wanted to get here as soon as we could.

INGA
We are the choices we make.

The offhanded comment discomfits Gwen a little.

GWEN
Yeah, no, sure.

Peter and Gwen exchange looks. This is getting awkward.

PETER
So... what now?

Long beat.

INGA
Give us a moment.

Inga returns inside the house, leaving Gwen and Peter in her peculiar wake.

UNKNOWN P.O.V.: From an upstairs window, furtively watching Gwen and Peter down below. *

BACK TO SCENE *

Peter watches as Jon disappears into the barn, but Gwen's attention turns to the farmhouse's upstairs window...

...where a lightly swaying curtain suggests someone's recent presence there. *

The front door opens, taking back Gwen's attention. Inga exits, catching the tail end of Gwen's gaze to the empty window. She steals a discreet look for herself.

8 EXT. FARMHOUSE - DAY 8

Inga walks Gwen and Peter across the property. Gwen assists Peter, hobbled by his lack of stamina and occasional coughing. Jon walks several paces ahead of all of them.

GWEN
So, is it just the two of you?

INGA
Just over fifty people live on the island.

GWEN
No, I meant here. At the house.

Jon utters something to Inga in their foreign tongue.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Sorry. I didn't mean to pry.

INGA
No, it was nothing you said.

JON
I told her the sheep still need to be fed.

Peter and Gwen apparently didn't think Jon spoke English. They also seem to question if that is what he truly said.

INGA
What about you?

PETER
Uh, no, I ate already.

INGA
Now it was me who was unclear. I was asking if it is just the two of you. Any children?

Gwen and Peter trade glances. This is a weighty subject.

GWEN
...No. It's just us.

INGA
Perhaps that is for the best.
(off Gwen's look)
Given the circumstances.

They soon reach and stop at a dirt PATH coursing up and over a Dartmouth-green hillside.

9 EXT. HILLSIDE - SECONDS LATER 9

CLOSE ON an old, rusty WHEELCHAIR as it snaps open. WIDER VIEW finds Jon unfolding it, gesturing for Peter to sit.

INGA
(off Peter's hesitation)
It is a fair distance from here.
Largely uphill.

Peter stares at it. A humbling reminder of his debilitation.

PETER
I used to jog every morning. Around four miles. I liked it.

Inga and Jon quietly regard Peter and Gwen, emotions incrementally being laid bare by the latter pairing.

INGA
(to Gwen)
In your correspondence, you spoke of -- the urgency.

Gwen nods. Her eyes blooming with tears.

PETER
I have about a year. Maybe less.

GWEN
Well, we're here to change that, right?

Gwen rubs Peter's arm, smiling encouragingly.

INGA
This path will bring you to the cave of the Huldufolk.
(off their confusion)
They are the keepers of this land.

PETER
I thought that was you.

INGA
I am merely a guide.

Peter studies Inga for a beat. A penumbra of doubt.

INGA (CONT'D)
You must enter alone. You will find the healing waters through the cave. Soak in them. Give promise your belief, and you shall be given promise of your health.

Hearing this, Gwen's brow beetles ever so slightly. As if it sounds familiar, but for reasons she can't quite pin down.

INGA (CONT'D)
Close your eyes, please.

Peter does as asked. Inga burns some sage, ceremoniously wafts it around him.

INGA (CONT'D)
You may open them.

Inga steps back. Her small ritual complete.

INGA (CONT'D)
It is time.

10 EXT. HILLSIDE - MOMENTS LATER 10

Gwen pushes Peter in the wheelchair, coursing up the path. The old, rusty wheels squeak with each slow turn.

11 EXT. FARMHOUSE - SAME 11

Inga and Jon stand and watch from afar as Gwen and Peter spread more and more distance.

Inga sighs heavily. Jon's hand reassuringly finds hers.

12 EXT. HILLSIDE - SAME 12

Gwen struggles to push as the hillside steepens. The wheels occasionally get snared on protruding stones.

PETER
I can walk a little.

GWEN
It's okay, I got it.

Her crouching posture redirects her eye-line to the back of the wheelchair, affixed to which is a laminated pocket.

It's small, not much larger than a notecard -- which is precisely what is contained in it.

As Gwen tries to decipher what's typewritten on the notecard, she gets stuck on another rock, distracting her.

She groans. Peter eases himself out of the chair.

PETER
It's fine. I can try.

As he does, he notices an OLDER WOMAN exiting the house, glancing behind her as she slips on a coat.

PETER (CONT'D)
Who's that?

Gwen turns to look downhill. Equally bemused.

GWEN
Her mother, I guess. They look alike.

PETER
They don't look too far apart in age, though.

Gwen looks back again. *"Hmmm. I dunno, then."* *

Gwen and Peter resume their journey uphill. Peter's steps are labored. He leans on the empty wheelchair Gwen pushes.

The Older Woman takes position alongside Inga and Jon, forming a chilling portrait as the three of them stare.

Peter and Gwen soon crest a hill, putting them out of view.

12A EXT. HILLSIDE - MORNING 12A

Gwen and Peter continue their slow uphill journey. Peter remains on foot as Gwen carts the empty wheelchair.

13 EXT. CAVE - MORNING 13

Peter is back in the wheelchair as Gwen pushes. He coughs a few times. Even the short time on his feet has taken a toll.

They arrive at the mouth of a CAVE. Dripping-black darkness. A thin, hollow wind imbues it with a prehistoric sentience.

PETER
You're sure about this?

GWEN
What other option is there?

PETER
Not go in the creepy cave.

GWEN
We've tried everything else.

A long beat. Peter clambers upright, standing from the wheelchair. Gwen assists him. Senses his hesitation.

GWEN (CONT'D)
I can go with you.

PETER
She said to go alone.
(beat)
Plus, there could be a bear in there.

GWEN
There aren't any bears in Iceland.

PETER
Famous last words.

GWEN
No bears, no wolves. No snakes. I read it somewhere. Wanna guess the top predator?

Beat.

PETER
That's okay.

A deep, steadying breath... and then Peter proceeds toward the cave, readying his cellphone's flashlight.

PETER (CONT'D)
Let the healing begin.

He stops just before entering...

PETER (CONT'D)
A walrus?

GWEN
Arctic fox.

PETER
I'd destroy an Arctic fox.

Gwen's smiling eyes brim with tears.

A long beat, then Peter continues into the cave, swallowed by the darkness an inch at a time.

14 INT. CAVE - MOMENTS LATER 14

Peter's flashlight pierces the dark. His labored breaths and phlegmy coughs echo against the entombing granite.

15 EXT. CAVE - SAME 15

Gwen waits by the wheelchair, her hair taunted by the wind. She crosses her arms, self-soothing, feeling uneasy. Watched.

UNKNOWN P.O.V.: Hidden. Observing her from a distance.

16 INT. CAVE - MOMENTS LATER 16

Peter continues through the mountain's tunnel-like gullet. Ahead, falling water is heard.

16A EXT. HEALING POOL - MOMENTS LATER 16A

Peter emerges from the other end of the tunnel...

...finding a breathtaking GROTTO ringing a CRYSTALLINE POOL sourced from two interlacing waterfalls.

Steam hovers just above the water's surface, indicating its warmth. A "Goldilocks" nexus where the fiery volcanic underworld coalesces with glacial meltwater.

16B EXT. HEALING POOL - MOMENTS LATER 16B

Peter stands at the water's edge. It glistens beckoningly as the rushing waterfalls resonate against the grotto's surrounding granite walls.

He finishes stripping down to his underwear. Seeing his body in such stark relief reveals the true extent of his sickness.

He stops for a moment, seeming to sense something -- or someone -- in the grotto's dark recesses.

PETER
Hello...?

His voice is absorbed by the rush of the falls.

He returns his attention to the water. A long beat.

The doubting pilgrim, wary of his baptism.

He takes a deep, unsteady breath...

...and then slowly descends into the water.

17 EXT. HILLSIDE - MORNING 17

Gwen pushes Peter in the wheelchair, back down the hillside. He's re-dressed. His hair still soaked, his mind unmoored.

GWEN
You feel any different?

PETER
I dunno. Wet?

She rubs his shoulder. Supportive.

18 EXT. FARMHOUSE - MORNING 18

Gwen and Peter are confounded when they soon come upon a small BONFIRE, burning unattended in a fire pit. A rusty FUEL CAN near it.

Sheep meander, no longer corralled. Added to that, Inga, Jon, and the Old Woman are nowhere to be found.

The squeaky wheelchair slows to a stop.

Silence save for a steady breeze undulating bedsheets on the drying line. A decided feeling of isolation.

18B EXT. FARMHOUSE - MOMENTS LATER 18B

Gwen takes a closer look at the fire. Rescues from it an OLD PHOTO of Inga and Jon, covered in soot. Also in it are a welter of personal effects -- the oddest of which is an outdated, early-2000s-era LAPTOP.

She uses a stick to slide the mostly-unmarred laptop away from the encroaching flames. Opens it...

It still works, barely hanging on to its battery life.

Peter steps out from inside the barn --

PETER
They're not in here, either.

Gwen considers the laptop for another moment. Closes it. Then turns her curiosity to the farmhouse.

19 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER 19

Small, cramped. Austere. Constructed from old, hand-hewn timber. Stone fireplace HEARTH. A small collection of books.

The front door creaks open...

GWEN
Hello? Inga?

She's met by stillness. She continues into the...

20 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS 20

Gwen arrives in the doorway. Surveying this empty room...

Canned and pickled vegetables stock the shelves, indicative of the importance of self-sufficiency.

UNKNOWN P.O.V.: Secretly surveilling her from the next room. *

BACK TO SCENE *

Gwen notices a NOTE on the table, paper-weighted in place by a small, rusty TEA TIN. Positioned in a manner seeming to ensure it doesn't avoid notice.

She picks up the note. Sees only a very short handwritten message on it, indecipherably scrawled in ICELANDIC.

She then picks up the tea tin. Pops open its lid. Discovers it contains tiny remnants of dried BLUE FLOWERS, ground into a tea powder.

As she considers all of this.....

CRASH! Glass SHATTERS upstairs, apprehending her attention. *

21 INT. FARMHOUSE - UPSTAIRS HALLWAY - MOMENTS LATER 21

Gwen finishes climbing the stairs, proceeding with trepidation. Her slow footfalls creak. *

There are two doorways, each facing the other.

GWEN
Hello?

She approaches the one to her right. The door halfway open.

Peeking inside, she sees nothing out of the ordinary. Only a spartan BEDROOM. No decorations. Just an unmade bed... and a bureau with clothes spilling out an open drawer.

A faint THUD. From behind her. She turns her attention to the other door. Also ajar.

Another THUD. There's something in there.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Inga...?

The silence hangs heavy in the air.

She approaches the door. Reaches for the handle. It groans open on its timeworn hinges...

22 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS 22

Gwen peers inside. Basic furnishings -- including a full-length MIRROR, the reflection in which she now sees herself. *

By the bed, injured from having crashed through a window, is a RAVEN. It flops on the floor, amid a scattering of broken glass, trying to fly. *

Gwen watches, unsure how to help but wanting to. *

The moment she steps closer -- *

-- the bird BURSTS into flight, violently escaping out the broken window. *

Gwen crosses to the window, pulling back the curtain and peering outside... *

Tracking the bird as it escapes skyward, noting its disquieting disorientation. *

As Gwen considers this, her view dips lower, affording a wider vantage of the rolling property. But there in the distance, seeming to be staring up at her, is what appears a tall SHADOWY FIGURE. *

PETER (O.S.)
Hey.

Gwen startles a bit, turning around. Peter is in the doorway.

GWEN
Jesus. Don't do that.

PETER
Sorry.

Gwen glances back outside the window...

...but the figure is no longer there.

PETER (CONT'D) *
What happened to the window? *

GWEN
There was a bird.

PETER
Pretty crazy bird.

GWEN
...Yeah.

In degrees, something then seems to dawn on Gwen. Her mouth draws down as she stares at Peter.

PETER
What?

GWEN
You made it up the stairs.

PETER
Huh. Yeah.

They both take a moment to contemplate this.

23 EXT. FARMHOUSE - DAY 23

Just by the front door. Gwen and Peter are seated on a bench, waiting. Peter rests his eyes, basking in the sunshine.

GWEN
(rereading Inga's note)
Probably says, "Be back soon." *

PETER
We can't wait too much longer. The ferry leaves at four.

GWEN
I asked that taxi driver to swing back by here at 3:30.

Peter glances at his phone -- which still has no service.

PETER
It's almost 3:30 now.

Gwen regards the bonfire, by now barely burning.

GWEN
What do you think's up with that?

Peter looks...

PETER
No idea.

...and, as he does, Gwen notices something peculiar on him.

GWEN
Peter...

PETER
Hm?

GWEN
Your neck.

PETER
What, what's wrong?

GWEN
The things -- the lesions...

PETER
They're gross, I know.

GWEN
(taken aback)
No... They're practically gone.

PETER
What?
(trying to see)
Seriously?

GWEN
When's the last time you even coughed?

PETER
Umm... hm. I don't know.

A long beat, then Peter stands and takes several steps. More sure in his gait than we've seen before.

He casts his gaze in the general direction of where the cave is (although it is too far away to actually see).

GWEN
How do you feel?

PETER
...Good.

Perplexity and astonishment dawning over them.

PETER (CONT'D)
Do you think it... helped?

Peter takes a moment to really appraise himself.

PETER (CONT'D)
Could it have? I mean...

GWEN
Yeah, I mean -- obviously I hope so. I'm just-- I wish Inga were here, so we could ask her.

PETER
Did you already pay her?

GWEN
She never really said how much it'd cost. So, no.

24 EXT. DOCK - DAY 24

The ferry sits in port. Icelandic CREW MEMBERS -- all of them veterans of the job -- unhurriedly prepare for departure.

The taxi pulls up to the taxi stand. Gwen and Peter climb out and proceed toward the ferry's gangway. *

25 EXT. FERRY - MOMENTS LATER 25

The ferry is untied from the dock. Gwen and Peter await departure near a bow-side railing. *

PETER
Maybe we can go on a trip.

Gwen gestures across the channel, to where a RED HELICOPTER crosses the sky above the mainland.

GWEN
How about a helicopter tour?

PETER
Over Paris.

They share a smile. Peter drapes his arm around her.

PETER (CONT'D)
There's so much we never did. Maybe we can now.

Gwen looks at Peter. Speaking to something deeper.

GWEN
Or at least... try.
(beat)
Again.

Peter's smile wavers, almost imperceptibly. He nods noncommittally... then pulls her closer, kisses her head.

The engines rumble, the ferry inches from shore. Gaining more momentum....

Gwen and Peter reveling in the wonderful inexplicability of it all. The renewed future this adventure has potentially bestowed upon them.

Spreading even more distance from shore now...

Peter clears his throat. Shifts a little.

The ferry adds even more space from the island...

Peter's hand finds his face. Grimacing now. Unsettled.

GWEN (CONT'D)
What is it? Peter...?

Just then --

BLOOD pours between Peter's fingers, spilling from his nose.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Oh my god. Peter!

It's GUSHING now. His skin falls ashen. His eyes loll back, he doubles over. Slumps onto the floor, landing hard.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Peter! Help! Somebody help!

Heads turn. Unsettled looks and stares.

26 INT. FERRY - WHEELHOUSE - SAME 26

The ferry captain, CAPTAIN KARLSSON, sees what's happening. Kills the engines. Hurries out to help.

27 EXT. FERRY - SAME 27

Gwen cradles Peter's limp body across her lap. Both of them soaked in his blood.

Crew Members rush over to help, as does Captain Karlsson.

CAPTAIN KARLSSON
(accented English)
What happened?

GWEN
I don't know, he -- he just started bleeding.

Peter coughs violently.

GWEN (CONT'D)
We have to get to a hospital.

CAPTAIN KARLSSON
It is in Reykjavik. Where we are going.

Gwen holds Peter closer as he continues coughing. Unsure what to do, feeling helpless and scared.

GWEN
What the hell was in that water? Did you drink any of it?

CAPTAIN KARLSSON
What water?

GWEN
There was a cave -- back on the island.

CAPTAIN KARLSSON
What cave?

GWEN
I don't know! Just a cave -- the Huldu--something.

The Captain and the Crew Members exchange glances. Visibly spooked by this.

GWEN (CONT'D)
It-- it was supposed to help him.

The crew argues in Icelandic, the word "Huldufolk" passing their lips. The Captain hurries back toward the wheelhouse.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Where's he going?

CREW MEMBER
We are going back.

GWEN
What?! No, we have to get to the hospital. Hey!

The Crew Members ignore Gwen's pleas as they disperse and begin preparations for a hasty return to the island.

28 EXT. DOCK - MOMENTS LATER 28

Now back at port, Gwen argues with the Crew Members as they briskly usher her and Peter off the ferry.

GWEN
This is ridiculous. What're we supposed to do?

CREW MEMBER
I am sorry. Please, go now.

PETER
Gwen...

Captain Karlsson wastes no time powering-up the engines. The vessel pulls out of port.

GWEN
(realizing)
Wait, our bags! Hey!

Peter hangs onto Gwen for support. They watch as the ferry pulls further and further away, stranding them.

29 EXT. ROAD - DAY 29

Gwen and Peter lumber along a seaside road, shrouded in low-lying fog. In time, Peter feels well enough to walk unaided.

30 INT. FARMHOUSE - EVENING 30

The door opens. Gwen pokes her head inside --

GWEN
Hello? Inga?

She's met by silence. To her confusion, the house remains empty. Peter rounds past her, entering.

GWEN (CONT'D)
What're you doing?

PETER
I wanna wash the blood off.

A groaning faucet is soon heard from the next room as Gwen remains near the front door. She steps back outside...

31 EXT. FARMHOUSE - CONTINUOUS 31

...and scans the property. A serpentine wind slithers across the tall grasses, cold as it billows wisps of her hair.

Looking down at the road, she sees a SEDAN on course to eventually pass by.

32 EXT. ROAD - MOMENTS LATER 32

Gwen finishes her downhill descent to the side of the road. She waves down the sedan as it draws nearer.

It slows to a stop. The driver climbs out. It takes Gwen a moment, but she recognizes him as the yellow-parka-wearing local man she previously saw near the seashore.

Blond forelock spills above his crisp blue eyes. His wool turtleneck crowds his angular, Nordic jawline. This is EINAR.

EINAR
(in Icelandic)
Are you all right?

GWEN
Sorry. Do you speak...?

EINAR
(in English)
I do.

He smirks, pleased with his rejoinder until he picks up on her discomposure.

GWEN
Do you happen to know the people who live here?

EINAR
No.

Gwen retrieves her cellphone. Pulls up the landscape photo she earlier took of the property.

GWEN
I have -- a picture...

She zooms-in on Inga in the background of the photo. But, Einar waves her off, clarifying --

EINAR
I have seen them, but I do not know them. They keep to themselves. That is the way here.

GWEN
So people don't typically wave down random cars?

EINAR
There typically aren't many cars to wave down.

They trade small smiles.

32A EXT. FARMHOUSE - SAME 32A

Having stepped out of the farmhouse, Peter cleans his hands with a rag, watching Gwen's interaction from a distance.

32B EXT. ROAD - SAME 32B

Honk-Honk. Einar's 8-year-old son, JONAS, taps the horn and calls out from the car --

JONAS
(in Icelandic)
Papa, I have to pee.

EINAR
He has to pee.

GWEN
Never mind. Thank you.

EINAR
My studio is down this road. If you need anything.

Gwen nods. She turns and is about to walk away when something strikes her --

GWEN
Oh, wait. Sorry.

She retrieves Inga's handwritten note from her pocket.

GWEN (CONT'D)
The woman -- she left us a note, but it's in Icelandic.

She hands it to him.

GWEN (CONT'D)
I was hoping you could tell me what it says.

Einar looks at what Inga wrote. Shakes his head.

EINAR
I cannot.

GWEN
Um, okay. Why can't you?

EINAR
Because that is not Icelandic.

Long beat.

JONAS
Papa.

Einar hands Gwen back the note and returns to his car, leaving her to ponder.

33 INT. FARMHOUSE - EVENING 33

Gwen returns. The house feels eerily still.

GWEN
Peter?

Looking around, she notes Inga's collection of canned vegetables. Old books as well, including an Icelandic FIELD GUIDE.

Then... something on one of the walls captures her curiosity. She steps closer, her brow creasing with unease...

There are ETCHED-IN LINES on the wallpaper. The kind prisoners scratch-out to track their imprisonment.

And there are THOUSANDS OF THEM, all noticeably losing shape and distorting as time went on.

She stares, the unease settling into her bones...

PETER (O.S.)
Who was that guy?

Gwen turns. Stares at Peter. Speechless at first.

GWEN
You're okay.

PETER
I think so, yeah.

Gwen regards him, quietly marveling at his convalescence.

PETER (CONT'D)
So, who was that?

GWEN
Oh. He lives here on the island. I asked him if he knows Inga and Jon.

PETER
Does he?

Gwen shakes her head. A beat, then Peter leaves the room.

As Gwen watches him go, she notices a LANDLINE PHONE CORD. Sure enough, she discovers it's attached to a PHONE.

Lifting the receiver, she hears a dial tone. A beat. She hangs up. However, a new idea seems to come to her...

PRE-LAP: The unmistakable hiss and screech of a dial-up internet connection.

34 INT. FARMHOUSE - NIGHT 34

Gwen uses Inga's charred laptop. The dial-up labors to connect. A long-forgotten, maddening process.

Eventually, Gwen connects. Pulls up Google Translate. She refers to Inga's handwritten message, typing it:

LANGUAGE DETECTED: "NORWEGIAN" *

Upon finishing and pressing Enter, Inga's message is translated:

"PLEASE FORGIVE US" *

The cryptic message sends a chill up Gwen's spine. Especially as she again considers the etched-in lines on the wall.

35 EXT. FARMHOUSE - NIGHT 35

Draped in darkness, the house exists in stillness, viewed from what could be a voyeuristic P.O.V.

A small amount of smoke spirals from the chimney. The nighttime wind whistles, snapping items on a clothesline.

36 INT. FARMHOUSE - SAME 36

Gwen holds the landline phone to her ear. She's met by a voicemail greeting from SARA, her younger sister.

SARA (V.O.)
Hi, you've reached Doctor Sara Mackenzie. Please leave me a message and I'll get back to you as soon as I can. Thank you. [Beep]

GWEN
Hey, it's me. You're probably at work -- but, um... I don't know, I'll try you again tomorrow.

Gwen hangs up. Thinks for a beat.

37 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER 37

Peter stokes a small fire he's started in the hearth.

PETER
This should help.

GWEN
I feel like we're squatters by this point.

PETER
I don't know what other choice we have. It's freezing outside.

Long beat.

GWEN
I called my sister.

Peter stops, looks at Gwen. Surprised to hear that.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Thought she might have some idea about what's going on with you.

PETER
Did she?

GWEN
I got her voicemail.

PETER
I'm surprised you called her.

GWEN
...Yeah.

Done stoking the fire, Peter hangs up the steel poker.

GWEN (CONT'D)
I, um, I also found out what Inga's note said.

Gwen hands Peter the note Inga left. Gwen has since written its translation, "PLEASE FORGIVE US," below Inga's message.

PETER
Forgive them for what?

Gwen shakes her head, ruminating.

38 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT 38

Gwen and Peter lie close together on the couch, warmed by a blanket they share and the fire crackling in the hearth.

Peter is asleep. Gwen's iPhone is plugged in, charging, as she meanwhile scrolls through old photos on it. No service.

She's several years back. Peter looks healthier. She seems happier. So does he. Photo after photo of them, together and very much in love.

But as the photos get closer to the present, we begin to notice a change in them and their relationship. Like a flip-book slowly revealing the dissolution of something special, ultimately showing Peter's stages of physical decline.

The last photo is the most recent: the photo of the farmhouse. Gwen again zooms-in on Inga.

Then she puts down her phone. Settles in to sleep. In time, she finally succumbs. The long, strange day finally submitting her into slumber. *

As she sleeps, a SHADOW crosses her face -- as if someone, or some thing, passed between the glow from the fireplace.

CUT TO:

39 EXT. HILLSIDE - MORNING 39

Distant and still, the farmhouse lies dormant as the sun ignites the horizon.

PRE-LAP: *RIIIIIIING!* *

40 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - MORNING 40

The landline phone jolts Gwen awake. To her confusion, Peter isn't next to her on the couch. The house feels eerily empty.

Unsure whether to answer, she eventually does.

GWEN
Hello?

SARA (V.O.)
Gwen?

GWEN
(surprised)
Sara?

SARA (V.O.)
Yeah. I just got off my shift and heard your voicemail.

GWEN
You alright? You sound...

SARA (V.O.)
I had a pretty bad flare-up at work. I'll be fine.
(then)
Where are you?

GWEN
Hm?

SARA (V.O.)
The number came up on my phone when you called. Where's three, five, four?

GWEN
Oh, um, we're in Iceland.

SARA (V.O.)
What? Why?

GWEN
Just-- We're just here.

SARA (V.O.)
Don't get all defensive; I was just asking. Does Mom know you're there?

GWEN
Why would--? No.

SARA (V.O.)
In case she's worried.

GWEN
I'm thirty-six years old; I don't have to check in with my mom. Maybe you should. *

SARA (V.O.)
(sighs)
You called. What do you want?

Gwen hears something, distracting her. Unsure if it's coming from inside or outside the house. She listens closer...

GWEN
I was gonna ask you... something.

SARA (V.O.)
About Mom?

GWEN
(even more distracted)
No. About... Peter--
(abruptly)
I'll call you back.

SARA (V.O.)
Is everything alright?

GWEN
It's-- I'll call you back.

Gwen hangs up. Calls out --

GWEN (CONT'D)
Peter?

Her calls for him go unanswered.

41 EXT. FARMHOUSE - MOMENTS LATER 41

Gwen exits the house, still searching. No sign of Peter anywhere. An empty panorama for as far as the eye can see.

42 EXT. HILLSIDE - LATER 42

Gwen treks along the footpath. Concern on the rise. Her feet slow to a stop when, in the distance, she sees...

Peter. Standing trancelike at the mouth of the cave. Staring with circumspect awe into the dark abyss.

43 EXT. CAVE - MOMENTS LATER 43

Gwen approaches, her perplexity rising. Peter is yet to detach his beguiled stare. His forehead glistens with sweat.

GWEN
What're you doing?

His mind reeling, he still can't pull himself away. Something quite stunning begins to occur to Gwen.

GWEN (CONT'D)
How did you get up here?
(off his silence)
Did you walk?

He barely shakes his head. Too astounded to muster much more. Finally looking at her...

PETER
I jogged.

Gwen stares at him with wonder and disquiet in similar measure. Peter is unable to explain it himself.

44 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - LATER 44

Peter stands near the doorway as Gwen packs-up their few belongings. She removes their passports from her purse, hands Peter his. Gets back to packing, close to being done.

PETER
What if we stuck around a little longer?

She stops, a bit surprised by the question.

GWEN
We can't.

Peter sighs. Gwen shoulders her purse. Ready to leave.

GWEN (CONT'D)
We need to go home.

PETER
I know, I wanna go home too, but...

She walks past him, out the door, expecting he'll follow.

45 EXT. FARMHOUSE - CONTINUOUS 45

Peter steps outside, but remains near the door.

PETER
It obviously worked. We got a second chance.

GWEN
Which would be incredible.

PETER
It is incredible.

GWEN
Yes, it's incredible.

PETER
Then why don't you seem it?

GWEN
I'm trying to understand it. You jogged up a hill, for God's sake. You could barely climb a flight of stairs last week.

PETER
Exactly.

Peter is chipping away at her, but some layers remain.

GWEN
How do we know Inga didn't poison you or something with that water?

PETER
Because I feel amazing.

GWEN
You didn't on the ferry. You seemed sicker than I've ever seen you.

PETER
Because I think it matters.
(off her confusion)
That I'm here on this island.

GWEN
You think being here...?

PETER
I think staying here.

Gwen's quite taken aback by what he's implying.

GWEN
That's not-- How could that even be possible?

PETER
I feel it.
(brooding)
And, I definitely felt it when I tried to leave.

HOLD ON Gwen, the sun playing enchantingly at her face as she considers this.

46 EXT. SHORELINE - DAY 46

A weatherstripped DINGHY lands INTO FRAME.

WIDER VIEW shows that Gwen lowered it from where it was beached against a jumble of coastal boulders.

Peter stands nearby, his hands jammed into his pockets.

PETER
This thing ain't gonna make it across the channel.

GWEN
That's not why we're doing it.

Gwen starts dragging the dinghy toward the incoming tide.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Maybe it was something about the ferry that made you feel that way -- the fumes or whatever. Or, I don't know, maybe the waves were worse yesterday; maybe you got seasick.

PETER
It wasn't any of that.

She reaches the shoreline. Slides the dinghy into the surf.

GWEN
How else are we gonna know that for sure?

Beat.

PETER
This is a bad idea.

She climbs aboard. Looks to Peter, waiting for him to step onboard the tiny vessel as well.

The water laps near his feet. Rife with uncertainty.

47 EXT. DINGHY - MOMENTS LATER 47

Slow, measured strokes bring the tiny boat further from land. Currently about fifty feet from it.

Gwen rows, keeping watch of Peter as she does. Scrutinizing his manner, his mien.

He seems unchanged -- though still quiet and introspective. As if trying to get a sense of himself.

So, Gwen carries on rowing. And rowing. Further... further...

A troubled sigh comes first in Peter...

Followed by gravelly throat-clearing...

And then quickening breaths. Sharpening discomfort...

GWEN
Peter...?

He grimaces. Teeth gnashing. Pained. Visibly unwell.

PETER
(through ragged breaths)
Turn around.

Gwen stops rowing, but doesn't yet turn around. Gliding on inertia. Still somewhat unconvinced.

PETER (CONT'D)
Gwen...

GWEN
Wait -- what if-- Maybe it's--

PETER
Turn around!

Peter is singed with PAIN. His back curls, his anguished SCREAMS echo across the channel.

His legs begin KICKING, flailing. Eyes rolled back to whites. Seizing. ROILING the tiny boat. His head JERKS, his forehead SMASHES against the hull, stamping it with blood.

GWEN
Oh my God. Peter. Peter!

Gwen lunges on top of him. Struggles to contain his WRITHING. The tiny boat sways -- swaying more now -- tipping!!

Gwen and Peter both go under. Their bodies shocked by the Arctic water.

Gwen is first to surface. GASPING for air. Clawing for the dinghy, unable to make purchase.

She finally grabs hold. Now looking around --

GWEN (CONT'D)
Peter? Peter?!

She finds him floating. Grabs him under the arms. Uses all she has to drag his rag-doll frame back toward the dinghy.

She slaps at his pale cheek, trying to rouse him.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Peter. Peter, please, wake up.
Please, wake up. I can't hold you.
Please.

Peter finally comes to. Coughing. Vomiting up water. His faculties restoring by inches.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Hold onto the boat. Hold-- there,
yeah-yeah.

Peter grabs onto the dinghy, both he and Gwen yielding to the water's frigid temperature. Gwen hollers, calling out --

GWEN (CONT'D)
HELP! HELP US!!

-- but there's no one else around.

She tries to help Peter onto the dinghy, but it's simply impossible.

They bob in the lapping waves. Gwen holds Peter close. Both of them freezing, close to drowning. Until --

An approaching sound -- a small outboard motor. Gwen looks, relived to see the vessel approaching.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Over-- over here!

As it draws nearer, SEE that it's being driven by Einar. He kills the engine, gliding closer as he scrambles to the bow.

EINAR
Give me your hand!

Gwen helps Peter over to Einar, who in turn pulls Peter onboard his boat -- which is no easy task.

EINAR (CONT'D)
Okay. Come-come. I've got you.

CLOSE ON Gwen, who, through her frozen, misty breaths, contemplates the deeper implications of this failed test.

CUT TO:

48 EXT. FARMHOUSE - DAY 48

Set against ancient gray skies and looming hills, the desolate dwelling cuts a rather unwelcoming picture.

49 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - SAME 49

Peter lies asleep in bed, convalescing. An ABRASION on his forehead, from when it smashed against the dinghy.

Nearby, dressed in her bra, hair still damp, Gwen slips into an ill-fitting wool sweater pulled from a dresser drawer. She puts on some lip gloss, puts it back into her purse.

She exits the room, quietly, so as to not rouse Peter.

50 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER 50

Gwen warms by the hearth, a plain-white mug of tea in hand, mid-conversation with Einar. He also sips tea, drinking from an alabaster mug bearing a faded design.

EINAR
(tactfully dismissive)
...Spirits, healing pools --
Iceland is rich in folklore.

GWEN
It spooked the people on the ferry enough to turn around and kick us off.

EINAR
They're old men. Superstitious.

His smirk fades when his playful rejoinder falls flat.

GWEN
There's no other explanation. It worked. He's better. When he's here. But, when he tries to leave...

Einar considers Gwen in her dark musing.

EINAR
Have you been able to contact the people who lived here?

She shakes her head, still lost in thought.

GWEN
They vanished.

EINAR
You're starting to sound like the old men on the ferry.

GWEN
What if it's not superstition? What if it's real?

Einar sighs gently, reluctant to ratify Gwen's beliefs.

EINAR
We're told tales as children -- about Huldufolk. The Hidden People. Beings living between worlds, protecting the land. Cursing those... who take from it.

This piques Gwen's attention. Einar shrugs it all off.

EINAR (CONT'D)
But, they're just stories. We're told them to frighten us into making good choices, to live good lives. People shouldn't need to be scared into doing what's right. *

GWEN
They also shouldn't lie, but -- they do.

Gwen hands him the photo fragment of Inga and Jon from when they were younger. Its edges are burnt and bent. Turning over the photo, he sees "ANNA & JON - 2004" handwritten on it.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Her real name is Anna. She and her husband burnt all their stuff before they left. Well, tried to, anyway.

Einar turns the photo back over, to the picture side.

GWEN (CONT'D)
So, even if they didn't actually vanish, they definitely wanted to never be found.

He looks closer at Anna/Inga in the picture. The photo shows her and her husband together at dinner. Smiling. Commonplace.

EINAR
So she wasn't actually a healer.

GWEN
That was another lie.

Einar hands her back the photo.

GWEN (CONT'D)
But the cave did heal Peter. The water.

Einar wanders closer to the wall. Mulling over the remnants of the etched-in day marker lines in the wallpaper.

EINAR
So how is it they were able to leave?

GWEN
I assume they took the ferry.

EINAR
That's not-- What I mean is, if it is some sort of curse, and if they were just normal people, why weren't they trapped here, too?

GWEN
...I don't know.
(thinking)
Unless -- they didn't leave.

As Gwen contemplates this, Einar's first to notice Peter now standing in the doorway. An unexpected robustness to him.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Peter.

PETER
Think we're good now.

EINAR
Right. Yes, of course.

GWEN
Thank you again.

Gwen collects Einar's mug. Peter notices the way Gwen's and Einar's hands ever-so-slightly touch during the pass-off.

51 EXT. FARMHOUSE - MOMENTS LATER 51

Clad in his yellow parka, Einar finishes walking down to his car. Before getting in, he looks back up to the farmhouse...

Peter stands at the front door, watching.

A beat, then Einar issues a small wave goodbye, to which Peter responds with a barely perceptible nod.

Einar gets in the car and drives away, stared after by Peter.

52 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER 52

Peter enters, still a bit in his head. To his bemusement, he finds Gwen putting on her coat.

GWEN
Think I'm gonna take a walk. See what I can find out.

Peter watches as she pockets the photo of Anna/Inga and Jon.

GWEN (CONT'D)
You gonna be okay?

PETER
...Yeah.

GWEN
I won't be long.

Gwen leaves the kitchen. She's then heard exiting the house.

A beat, then Peter notices the two used tea mugs, now near the sink. The sight alone seems to sharpen his jealousy.

53 EXT. ROAD - DAY 53

A light fog. The surrounding hills tumble to the sea.

With the photo of Anna/Inga and Jon in hand, Gwen treks along the coastal road. Looking around, scanning the hillside.

54 INT. FARMHOUSE - STAIRCASE - DAY 54

Peter ascends the old wooden stairs. When he's about two-thirds of the way up --

CRASH. The sound of glass shattering, coming from downstairs. *

A beat, then he climbs back toward the bottom.

55 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - SECONDS LATER 55

Upon entering, he finds the room still empty -- and yet Gwen's plain-white mug has somehow shattered to the floor.

The faint, distant sound of bleating sheep underscores the unsettling discovery.

56 EXT. ROAD - DAY 56

Gwen continues her roadside trek. Searching, she sees a HOUSE up a hillside. One of only a few within sight for miles.

57 INT. FARMHOUSE - STAIRCASE - DAY 57

Peter throws the broken shards into the trash. But then he stops... his brow laddering as he plucks one in particular.

Inspecting it closer, he sees this broken portion of the mug's rim is smudged with Gwen's red lip gloss.

A beat, then he retrieves Einar's intact mug from near the sink. Scrutinizes its rim, searching for traces of the gloss. Rubbing his thumb along it now. Even smelling it, comparing its smell to scent the gloss left on Gwen's mug shard.

He seems unconvinced one way or the other.

58 EXT. HILLSIDE HOME - DAY 58

Small, cottage-like. Still a fair distance away as Gwen journeys up the verdant slope, ascending above the faint layer of low-lying fog down by the road.

She stops walking halfway up the hill. Looks around. As if suddenly feeling watched.

A long beat... then she resumes her trek, not entirely convinced she's alone.

59 INT. FARMHOUSE - STAIRCASE - DAY 59

Peter starts up the stairs. Something building inside him, he begins to climb faster.

Reaching the top, ruminating on something, he turns and descends the staircase. Muttering to himself, as if relitigating his beachside conversation with Gwen.

PETER
Then why are we doing it?

Once at the bottom, he turns -- and climbs the stairs again. Even faster this time. His footfalls hammering the wood.

Once at the top, he turns and troops back down. Then, even faster back up. Two steps at a time.

Grunting now. Pushing himself. Proving himself. His power. His masculinity. Perhaps even his desirability.

60 EXT. HILLSIDE HOME - DAY 60

Gwen approaches the front door. Knocks. Waits. No answer.

As she walks away, she slows when she hears something...

A thin but fairly constant sound seems to be coming from... somewhere. Listening closer, it sounds... *like a crying baby.* *

Still listening. The breeze bending the tall grasses around her. Her breathing deepens. Affected.

The home's front door opens. Standing there, a bit surprised to have a visitor, is a provincial ICELANDIC WOMAN, (27). A few blond CHILDREN in her tow, and a crying NEWBORN BABY in her arms -- summarily resolving the mystery behind the cries.

ICELANDIC WOMAN
Hallo?

Returning to ground, Gwen walks back to the front door.

GWEN
Sorry. Hi. My name's Gwen Lawson.

Gwen offers her hand. The Icelandic Woman, not expecting that, nevertheless obliges.

GWEN (CONT'D)
I was hoping you could help me with something.

Gwen realizes, from the Woman's apologetic expression, that she doesn't speak English. So, Gwen produces the old photo of Inga/Anna and Jon, hoping the visual aid will help.

A hint of recognition crosses the Woman's face.

GWEN (CONT'D)
You know them?

The Woman points down the road, unsure even about which direction she should be pointing.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Have you seen them recently? These people -- have you seen them here anywhere?

The Woman regards the photo again, and as she does, Gwen finds herself looking at the baby. An obvious longing.

The Woman's 3-year-old BOY, standing by her side, meanwhile tugs at her dress, trying to get her attention as he stares far behind Gwen. Mostly curious, but also unsettled.

ICELANDIC WOMAN
(distracted with photo)
Augnablik.

She's asked the young boy to essentially "Hang on a moment." But the child persists, then points and quietly says...

BOY
Huldufolk.

The Woman stops. Abruptly. Looks where the boy points, searching. Gwen reacts to what she thinks she heard.

GWEN
Did he say -- ?

Gwen turns and looks as well. Like the Woman, she doesn't see anything or anyone out there on the hillside.

Nevertheless, the Woman hands back the photo. Hastily closing the door, ushering her children inside behind her.

GWEN (CONT'D)
No, um, wait-- What did--

The door closes. Dead-bolted from the other side.

Gwen sighs. A distant FOGHORN captures her attention. Looking seaward, she sees the FERRY pulling into port.

61 INT. FARMHOUSE - DAY 61

Peter sweats. His breaths heavy but healthy. Still running the stairs. Fast. Double-stepping.

PETER
(mimicking Gwen)
"That's not why we're doing it."
(responding as himself)
Then why are we doing it, Gwen? Why are we doing it?

Something deep in him emerging. The raw exertion a purge.

He reaches the bottom. Stops. Finally needing to catch his breath. In... out... in... o--

His breath catches. Because... he hears... squeaking.

Listening closer. It's coming from upstairs.

61A INT. FARMHOUSE - UPSTAIRS HALLWAY - SECONDS LATER 61A

Peter slowly ascends the stairs. Hunting down the sound like a dog tracking a scent.

It's coming from behind the bedroom door. The sound now unmistakable: coiling and uncoiling bedsprings.

He draws closer. The stressed bedsprings are joined by pleasured moans.

The flood of sunlight, spilling out under the door, intermittently eclipsed by shifting bodies inside the room.

PETER
Gwen? Gwen?!

No reply. The mattress springs get louder. The headboard thudding against the wall. The moans far from indiscreet.

Peter grabs the doorknob. It's locked. He BANGS his hand against the door.

PETER (CONT'D)
Hey! Open the door!

SMASH! ... SMASH! Now DRIVING his shoulder against the door. *
Harder, harder. The sounds from inside the room matching his increasing intensity.

PETER (CONT'D)
Open the door!! Gwen, open the--

SMASH! The lock finally breaks, the door opens -- *

61B INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS 61B

-- but the room's empty. Silent. The bed neatly made.

Sunlight flooding in through the window. Almost tauntingly.

Peter, in the custody of disbelief, slowly catches his breath, the misplaced anger yet to fully leave him.

62 OMIT 62

63 OMIT 63

64 EXT. DOCK - DAY 64

The ferry idles, about to cast off. Gwen hurries toward it. Captain Karlsson and Crew recognize her, instantly uneasy.

CAPTAIN KARLSSON
No-no, I cannot take you.

GWEN
I just want to ask you something.

The Captain turns and marches off without another word, proceeding toward the wheelhouse.

Gwen removes, from her pocket, the Inga/Anna and Jon photo. Walks it over to one of the crew members pulling up ropes, a bit more sympathetic-looking than the other men.

GWEN (CONT'D)
These people. Please, these people -
- Did you take them on the ferry?

He's trying to ignore her. But she seems to be wearing him down. Her pleas raw and difficult to ignore.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Did they leave the island?
(off his silence)
You can at least tell me that.

He stops. Finally meeting her eyes.

CREW MEMBER
Yes.

GWEN
Was there an older woman with them?

He looks around, checking to see if anyone else is watching.

CREW MEMBER
Yes. Now, please.

GWEN
Did anything happen? Like what happened to my husband.
(off his reluctance)
Just answer me. Did anything--

CREW MEMBER
No.

Sharp and unambiguous, his answer stops Gwen in her tracks.

CREW MEMBER (CONT'D)
Now, please, go.

He turns and walks down the hull to pull up other ropes.

GWEN
No, wait.

Captain Karlsson hollers over a directive to the Crew Member, telling him to get moving.

CAPTAIN KARLSSON
Dragðu upp strengina.

Gwen tracks after the Crew Member, alongside the ferry.

GWEN
I know you believe it; I saw how you all acted that day. Some woman here, she's young; she does, too.

The Crew Member feels his crew mates' eyes on him.

GWEN (CONT'D)
It's not superstition, is it?

He finishes with the ropes. Gwen's desperation crescendoes.

GWEN (CONT'D)
We didn't take anything -- from the land, or, or whatever, we didn't -- do anything.

This finally stops him. His expression grave.

CREW MEMBER
You did.

Beat. Gwen left flummoxed. Flailing.

GWEN
What did we do? What if we put it back, whatever it is -- will it stop?
(re: photo)
How did they make it stop?

The Crew Member pauses. Perhaps about to answer... but he instead seems to hedge.

CREW MEMBER
You should never have come.

He turns and walks away. The ferry motors up.

Gwen watches, despairing as the ferry pulls from port and silently begins disappearing into the distance.

65 EXT. BARN - EVENING 65

Peter wanders past. Still brooding.

He sees the AXE stuck in the chopping block. He stops. Places a log on the block. Picks up the axe...

CHOP! Splits it. Places another log on the block... *

CHOP! Splits it. Feeling the weight of the axe in his hands. *

66 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - EVENING 66

The laptop screen shines against Gwen's face. Next to her is the "PLEASE FORGIVE US" letter Inga/Anna left behind, as well as the photo fragment Gwen recovered from the fire pit.

She Googles: "ANNA + JON" -- the names handwritten on the back of said photo. Then adds "NORWAY" to the search terms.

The returns are broad and unhelpful. She sighs, her mind reeling.

Peter enters, carrying an armful of firewood. Adds logs to the fire. Looks over, seeing what Gwen is up to.

A long beat, then he exits the room without a word.

Gwen waits until he's gone... and then clears the search bar.

Types something new: *"HULDUFOLK"* *

Images from folklore appear. Various drawings and paintings depicting nightmarish figures sculpted from the absence of light. Their elongated, bipedal stance a chilling mimicry of the human form. Terrifying, sinister silhouettes.

Beneath the images, Gwen peruses information about these otherworldly beings.

Certain words and phrases stand out:

"...origins shrouded in ancient Icelandic myth..." *

"...the Hidden People's guardianship of the land and dominion *
over its hidden energies..." *

"...often occurring at the edge of one's vision -- a fleeting *
movement, an unusual shadow..." *

67 EXT. BARN - SAME 67

As Peter's about to chop more wood, he catches something on the edge of his vision.

Turning to look, he catches only its trailing shadow before it, too, dissolves into the darkness.

68 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - SAME 68

And then, with trepidation, Gwen adds the word: *"CURSE"* *

Specific words and phrases capture her attention:

"...not acts of kindness, but insidious tests designed to *
expose moral weakness. Acceptance is not a blessing, but a *
mark of selfishness that invites their malevolence." *

"...agonizing and relentless; a slow, unforgiving decay of *
the body, mind, and spirit." *

Gwen stares at the screen. Stranded in silence.

69 EXT. CAVE - NIGHT 69

Clutching her coat closed tightly, Gwen finishes a walk to the impenetrably dark entrance of the cave.

There she stands in a cold, thin breeze, staring into the void. Trying to make sense of it all.

UNKNOWN P.O.V.: Staring back at her from deep within.

CUT TO:

70 EXT. FARMHOUSE - DAY 70

Gwen hangs wet laundry on a line, draping garments and bedsheets. As she continues doing so...

UNKNOWN P.O.V.: Surreptitiously watching her from the between the swaying sheets. Creepily intimate. Stalking closer.

71 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY 71

Gwen cleans and chops vegetables. Tired and a bit bleary-eyed, she accidentally cuts her hand. Blood spills. She cleans the wound at the sink.

Until she slows to a stop. Uneasy. Feeling stalked in this empty room. She turns off the faucet. Listens.

GWEN
Peter...?

Her call goes unanswered. But she still doesn't feel alone.

Just then... the pantry door creaks open behind her.

Turning slowly toward it, Gwen waits in silence.

A thin but fairly constant sound seems to be coming from in there. Gwen once again thinks she hears... *a crying baby.* *

She steps closer. Closer. The crying fades away.

She slowly reaches for the door... Ghosts it open...

It's quite dark in there. Indiscernibly deep.

She reaches for a pull cord, attached to a naked bulb. Click.

A meager collection of canned vegetables, but nothing out of the ordinary or worthy of concern.

A long beat...

...then Gwen turns and exits the pantry, pulling the lightbulb cord during her departure. Click. The pantry goes dark, revealing --

-- a silhouetted WRAITHLIKE FIGURE behind her. Our first real encounter with those known to folklore as the Huldufolk.

Gwen closes the door, unaware.

72 OMIT 72

73 OMIT 73

CUT TO:

74 EXT. HILLSIDE - NIGHT 74

The wind blows cold and harsh, whipping at the farmhouse, observed from afar. A single, dim light on inside.

75 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - SAME 75

Gwen and Peter eat a meager dinner. Both look mentally tired and taxed. Some tension between the two of them.

She keeps glancing over at the pantry door. Peter notices.

PETER
What?

GWEN
I could've sworn I heard something in there earlier. It sounded... like crying.
(beat)
Like a baby crying.

Peter stops. A beat, then he returns to his meal.

PETER
It's probably just the wind.

GWEN
Right. I forgot you're an expert on wind sounds.

He flicks his eyes in her direction.

GWEN (CONT'D)
(long beat)
There's something here.

Peter momentarily stops again, but betrays little.

GWEN (CONT'D) *
I feel it watching me. All the *
time *

GWEN (CONT'D) *
(off Peter's silence) *
Do you? *

He stops for a fleeting moment. Almost imperceptibly. Then keeps cutting the meat on his plate.

Traces of blood seep through Gwen's makeshift bandaging. She addresses it, grimacing. Peter notices this as well.

PETER
How'd that happen?

GWEN
I cut it while I was doing the vegetables.

PETER
Don't let it get infected.

GWEN
I was thinking I could head over to the mainland. Find a pharmacy.

Beat. Peter stabs a forkful of food, rejecting the idea.

PETER
They won't let you on the ferry.

GWEN
Maybe there are other boats.

He searches her. Suspicious.

GWEN (CONT'D)
I would come right back.

His stare fixes for an unsettlingly long time.

GWEN (CONT'D)
What?

PETER
I keep thinking about what happened on the dinghy.
(beat)
And why you insisted we try it -- when you knew what would happen.

GWEN
I didn't know. That's why we tried. I was trying to help you.

PETER
By almost drowning me?

GWEN
I saved you from drowning. If that guy hadn't shown up, you probably would have.

Peter harrumphs through his clenched chewing.

PETER
Don't act like you don't know his name.

GWEN
That's the truth.

PETER
You know his name.

GWEN
Fine, I know his name, whatever.

PETER
You even put lipstick on for him.

GWEN
What are you talking about?

Peter places the mug shard on the table. An implicit accusation. Gwen looks at it, sees the red smudge.

GWEN (CONT'D)
It's lip gloss. My lips were chapped. *

PETER
I couldn't tell if it was on his mug, too. Maybe.

Gwen bridles at the implication. Peter presses on, stoking the embers of Gwen's anger.

PETER (CONT'D)
Have you seen him since?

GWEN
I've only seen you. And this house. And this fucking island. And God forbid I want to leave, one time, so I can get some medicine.

A long beat, then...

PETER
This was your idea.

GWEN
I was trying to help you.

PETER
Please stop saying that.

Beat.

PETER (CONT'D)
If I have to be here, so do you.

He gets up and exits the kitchen. Gwen sits in silence as he is heard heading upstairs.

76 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - SECONDS LATER 76

Peter enters the moonlit room. He takes off his sweater and stands by the bed. Sighs deeply.

77 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - SAME 77

Gwen remains at the table as Peter is heard shutting the bedroom door upstairs. She regards the word "JOY" tattooed on her wrist. Contemplating it. A soft sigh escapes her.

CUT TO:

78 EXT. FARMHOUSE - DAY 78

It's winter. The wheelchair is folded-up and covered in frost, cast aside and forgotten.

79 EXT. BARN - SAME 79

CHOP! An AXE splits a piece of firewood. Peter stacks it atop a pile, prepares the next piece on the chopping block. *

His exhalations cloud in the cold.

CHOP! Splits the next piece. Stacks it. *

He swings the heavy axe with ease. His back and shoulders appear wider, fuller. Filling out Jon's left-behind clothing, yet a weary hollowness exists behind his eyes. His hair disheveled and outgrown. * *

Placing the next piece onto the block, he spies Gwen across the frost-covered property, lugging a basket in the garden.

80 EXT. FARMHOUSE - GARDEN - SAME 80

An impoverished yield of vegetables in Gwen's woven basket. The frigid wind howls past.

She look under-slept and bedraggled in Inga's poorly fitting, left-behind clothes.

She kneels beside one of few viable carrots, pulls it from the ground. Places it in her basket. The cut on her hand, reddened by signs of infection, adding to the arduousness.

As she checks the wound, something nearby catches her eye...

A small patch of the distinct-looking BLUE FLOWERS, peeking through the frost. Vibrant. Frozen in bloom.

She plucks one of them. Regards it with curious study. A beat, then she walks off with it, leaving her basket behind.

81 EXT. BARN - SECONDS LATER 81

CHOP! Peter chops another piece of firewood. *

As he places another piece on the chopping block, he notices Gwen crossing the property.

A hint of suspicion over the hurried set of her her stride * and the seemingly furtive glance in his direction.

82 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER 82

The plucked blue flower in hand, Gwen checks the cupboards. Pushing aside various items, searching, she soon finds what she evidently was looking for: the small TEA TIN.

Opening it, she confirms that it contains ground-down dried petals, clearly sourced from the same blue flower.

83 EXT. BARN - SAME 83

CHOP! Peter takes on a rounded, more brutal posture as * insecurity and anger rise within him.

A few sheep amble close to his woodpile, stealing bites from a torn bag of grain. He shoves them along.

84 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - SAME 84

Pages flip by in an old book. The Icelandic field guide. Gwen peruses the section on indigenous flora, her finger glide-reading past the many illustrations.

Her eyes skid back up the page when she spots the flower. Blue. Vibrant. And with a SKULL AND CROSSBONES next to its scientific name:

"RANUNCULUS ACONITUN" *

She peers outside, sees that Peter is still chopping wood. Her reason for checking unknown, if slightly suspicious.

RIIIIIIIING!! ... RIIIIIIIING!! *

The landline phone rings, jarring her a little.

After marking the book page, she places it on the table as she exits the kitchen and crosses into the --

84A INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS 84A

-- and approaches the ringing phone, unsure if she should answer. She finally does.

GWEN
Hello?

There's no reply on the other end -- only static. The house's wood frame meanwhile squeals against the wind.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Hello...?

The static gives way. A voice finally breaking through --

SARA (V.O.)
--r me--. Gwen? Hello?

GWEN
Sara?

SARA (V.O.)
Oh my god, you're still there?

GWEN
...Yeah.

SARA (V.O.)
I've been trying you on your cellphone for a month.

GWEN
I don't get service here.

SARA (V.O.)
I'd lost this number; I honestly didn't expect you to pick up when I found it. What is it, a hotel?

GWEN
It's... no. It's a house.

SARA (V.O.)
Whose house?

GWEN
Some... people's house.

SARA (V.O.)
Then why are you answering their phone?

GWEN
I don't need this right now.

SARA (V.O.)
It's a pretty reasonable question.

GWEN
I'm asking you, please, stop it.

SARA (V.O.)
What am I doing?

GWEN
You treat me like I'm a child. Do you know what that feels like, to have your little sister talk to you like you do to me?

SARA (V.O.)
What are you even doing there?

GWEN
Nothing. We're just here. Do I ask that any time you go somewhere?

Things calm down.

UNKNOWN P.O.V.: Watching Gwen from the next room.

SARA (V.O.)
Seriously, Gwen. People are getting worried.

GWEN
Who?

SARA (V.O.)
Well, me, for starters. Mom. *

BACK TO SCENE *

Gwen is forlorn. Struck by a longing for her former life.

SARA (V.O.)
Why are you still there?

GWEN
(long sigh)
It's been good -- for Peter.

SARA (V.O.)
What about for you?
(off Gwen's silence)
Because you don't exactly sound good.

Gwen doesn't reply. Tears pearl in her eyes. Fighting back her swelling emotions, absently rubbing at her infected hand.

SARA (V.O.)
Why haven't you called me?
(off the non-reply)
Let me talk to Peter.

Gwen peeks out the curtain. Sees Peter over by the barn.

GWEN
He's outside, chopping wood.

SARA (V.O.)
(incredulous)
He's chopping wood?

GWEN
He's-- yeah. He's better.

Sara sighs deeply.

SARA (V.O.)
Gwen...

GWEN
You don't know what's happening, Sara.

SARA (V.O.)
I know you.

GWEN
(taking umbrage)
This is why I didn't call.

SARA (V.O.)
People donated money for him to get treatment, not for you to go on vacation.

GWEN
He did get treatment.

SARA (V.O.)
Did he get his bloodwork done? Has he had a PET scan? --

GWEN
-- That's--

SARA (V.O.)
-- What were his serum protein levels?

GWEN
That's not--

SARA (V.O.)
Then you don't know he's getting better. You're hoping he is, and I obviously get that, but--

GWEN
He's not getting better, he is better. He's not -- he's not sick anymore.

Beat.

SARA (V.O.)
This isn't healthy. For either of you.

Gwen starts to break down. Coming undone.

SARA (V.O.)
You need to come home.

GWEN
He can't.

SARA (V.O.)
I can try getting him into another trial at the hospital.

GWEN
I'm telling you. He can't leave.

SARA (V.O.)
If he feels healthy enough to chop wood -- assuming that's the truth --

GWEN
-- Annnd there you go. --

SARA (V.O.)
-- then he can get on a plane.

GWEN
Listen to me. Please. He can't leave.

Beat.

SARA (V.O.)
Then, maybe you should.

Gwen seems to give this serious thought. As she does, she notices something outside --

-- Peter's no longer out there chopping wood.

Just then, she hears the front door open, followed by heavy, booted footsteps now getting closer.

GWEN
I have to go.

SARA (V.O.)
Seriously, Gwen.

The footsteps draw even closer. Gwen hastens to end the call.

GWEN
Okay.

SARA (V.O.)
I love you. I do.

GWEN
...I love you too.

SARA (V.O.)
Call me if you need anything.

GWEN
Okay. Bye.

Gwen hangs up. Sees Peter standing imposingly in the doorway.

PETER
Who was that?

GWEN
Sara.

He stares interminably. Studying her.

GWEN (CONT'D)
What?

A spare shake of his head is the limit of his response. A beat, then Gwen angles past him and exits the house.

Peter watches her for a beat, then exits the house as well, heading in the opposite direction as her. UNKNOWN P.O.V.: Staring after Peter as he walks away.

85 EXT. BARN - MOMENTS LATER 85

Peter's stern breaths congeal in the cold as he trudges back to his woodpile -- only to find it's been completely toppled.

He looks for the culprit, furious and flummoxed to an equal extent, but there's nobody out there but him.

In a fit of rage, he swipes the axe -- and starts WHACKING at the chopping block itself.

Over and over -- until the axe blade gets wedged into it. He's too winded to extract it, so there it stays.

During his incensed, vaporous breaths...

...he catches sight of something in his peripheral. It's Einar, in his hooded yellow parka, heading up the hill path.

86 EXT. HILLSIDE - MOMENTS LATER 86

Peter troops through the encroaching darkness, trying to catch up with Einar, who keeps moving in and out of sight.

PETER
Hey!

Einar continues apace uphill, not responding.

87 EXT. CAVE - MOMENTS LATER 87

Darkness has set in unnaturally fast.

Peter crests the last of the hills, just in time to catch sight of Einar entering the cave.

88 EXT. HEALING POOL - MOMENTS LATER 88

Peter crawls out from the tunnel-like cave, reaching the grotto. He freezes, stunned as he sees --

-- a MAN and a WOMAN, naked together near the twin waterfalls. Kissing intensely. The man's back faces Peter; the woman's identity blocked by the man's broad frame.

Peter's eyes dart to the surrounding rocks. A jumble of clothing. Among them...

Einar's yellow parka.

And Gwen's familiar jacket.

Peter retreats from view. Seething. Fists clenched. A beat, then he rounds back, only to now find --

-- there's nobody there.

Nonplussed, he approaches the waterfalls. Searching.

Nothing. No one.

Perplexed, standing with his back against a veil of darkness, trying to make sense of it all...

JET-BLACK HANDS THRUST THROUGH AND GRAB HIS HEAD, YANKING HIM BACKWARDS IN A HEARTBEAT!!

SMASH TO:

89 EXT. BARN - SAME 89

Peter snaps back to reality, returning from his dark reverie. It's still daytime. His axe sticks out from the chopping block, where he left it.

His disquietude lingers. He yanks the axe free, casts his gaze to the garden...

Gwen is still not there, but her left-behind basket remains.

90 EXT. ROAD - DAY 90

Not a single car passes as Gwen walks along this lonely stretch. Gusts of wind are inconsistent but harsh.

91 EXT. ROAD - LATER 91

Gwen finally comes upon a house up ahead. Barn-like in design, and with Einar's small boat trailered out front.

92 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - DAY 92

Peter enters. Finds the room empty. He calls out...

PETER
Gwen?

No response. Only silence.

93 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER 93

Peter looks in here as well. Empty. He's about to exit -- when he notices the plucked blue-petal flower on the table.

94 EXT. EINAR'S STUDIO - DAY 94

Gwen knocks on the door. Shivering as she waits. Einar finally answers, surprised to see her.

EINAR
You're still here.

GWEN
...Yeah.

EINAR
It is cold. Please, come in.

95 INT. EINAR'S STUDIO - MOMENTS LATER 95

An unpretentious mixed residential space filled with Einar's metalworks art.

GWEN
It's a nice space.

EINAR
I sold my studio in Reykjavik. Things are much cheaper here. And partly subsidized; certain utilities. I'm saying boring things.

Gwen smirks as she looks over more of his artworks.

GWEN
Did you make all these?

EINAR
I did, yes.

Einar's landline phone rings.

EINAR (CONT'D)
Excuse me.

He picks up a wall-mounted phone --

EINAR (CONT'D)
Hallo?

Gwen watches him for a moment during his brief, Icelandic-spoken conversation. Unable to ignore his attractiveness.

The call ends, Einar hangs up and returns.

EINAR (CONT'D)
My apologies.
(then)
So, have you come to purchase something? This turtle, perhaps?

He gets her to crack a smile.

GWEN
I was hoping you might have some antiseptic cream.

She refers him to the infected cut on her hand.

He takes her hand in his. Examines the cut. She wasn't expecting this, but clearly appreciates the human contact.

EINAR
Hm.

He lets go of her hand and begins rummaging through a drawer.

EINAR (CONT'D)
I should have some. Somewhere.
(finding some)
Here we are.
(asking for her hand)
Let me see.

Einar dresses Gwen's wound with skill and care.

GWEN
You seem like you've done this before.

EINAR
I cut myself more times than I'd like to admit. Occupational hazard.

They share a spare smile. Gwen's gaze lingers on him when he returns his attention to his task.

96 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY 96

Drawing closer to the flower, Peter sees the field guide and tea tin as well, all suspiciously collected together.

97 INT. EINAR'S STUDIO - DAY 97

As Einar continues dressing her wound, Gwen notices his yellow parka, on a hook, and a child's coat next to it.

GWEN
Is your son here?

EINAR
Jonas attends school in Reykjavik.

GWEN
Is he your only child?

Pride and felicity fill Einar's nod.

EINAR
He is everything to me.

Gwen absorbs this, suddenly betraying her yearning.

EINAR (CONT'D)
And you? Any children?

GWEN
We considered trying again, but...

EINAR
Again?

GWEN
It's, um-- No. No, we don't--
(leaving it here)
It wasn't meant to be.

Her forced smile. Her glistening eyes. Einar sees not to press any further.

98 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY 98

Peter opens the field guide to a marked page. Sees information about about the blue flower Gwen has collected:

"...found scarcely in coastal areas of Iceland." *

"...poisonous to animals and humans..." *

"...lethal if consumed even in small quantities." *

Peter coils tightly with rage as he draws a dark conclusion.

99 INT. EINAR'S STUDIO - DAY 99

Einar finishes dressing Gwen's wound. He offers to let her keep the tube of antiseptic cream.

EINAR
In case you need more.

GWEN
(gently declining)
Peter will wonder where I got it.

Gleaning the subtext, Einar puts away his first-aid kit.

Gwen approaches a window. Her eyes linger on Einar's trailered boat, outside.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Do you bring him yourself?

EINAR
I'm sorry?

GWEN
Your son. Over to the mainland, for school.

EINAR
Only two days per week. He stays there overnight on the other days.

Einar joins Gwen at the window.

EINAR (CONT'D)
(re: his boat)
I'm having engine trouble, though.
He will need to take the ferry.

He considers her. She looks tired. Worn down. The reason for her veiled interest in the boat becoming clear.

EINAR (CONT'D)
I imagine you could too by now, as well. Should you ever... need to. Perhaps they won't recognize you.

Gwen notices him noticing. Walks away, pensively taking in his metalworks art.

Most of his collection is postmodernist and abstract. But, some are folklorish, harkening back to older, darker times.

GWEN
I thought you said this stuff is nonsense.

EINAR
It is. But it sells well. So.

Gwen stops before a particular piece. Given pause. Staring at it with creeping unease.

EINAR (CONT'D)
When I last saw you, you were trying to locate the people who lived in that home.

GWEN
I still am.

Gwen's gaze never detaches from the piece.

WE FINALLY SEE IT.

It's intimidatingly large and elaborate. But, more than that, it bears a chilling resemblance to the Huldufolk.

The sinister-looking piece seems to loom over Gwen.

CUT TO:

100 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT 100

Dinnertime. Gwen and Peter sit in heavy silence. The wind outside presses and squeals the home's wood walls.

Gwen has barely touched her meal. Peter scarfs down his last forkfuls. Wipes his mouth, eyeing her probingly.

The tea kettle whistles. Gwen gets up, turns off the burner. Prepares one mug.

Upon placing in front of Peter, he sees it's same alabaster mug Einar previously drank from.

He considers it, then watches as she rounds back to her seat.

PETER
None for you?

She shakes her head. Peter takes her measure, discreetly eyeing the fresh dressing covering her wounded hand.

PETER (CONT'D)
It's good for you. Healthy.

GWEN
Then drink it.

Peter regards the mug of tea once again. Suspicion rising. Gwen watches as his fingers play at the rim.

After a long beat...

PETER
So -- what's the plan?

GWEN
What plan?

PETER
The plan.

GWEN
I have no idea what you're--

PETER
For how you're gonna run off with who you were on the phone with earlier.

GWEN
I told you, I was talking to Sara.

PETER
Since when do you two say "I love you?"

Gwen sits back in her chair. Exasperated.

GWEN
You're losing it.

PETER
I am?
(long beat)
I see you, you know.

GWEN
What are you talking about?

Peter places the tea tin on the table. Gwen shifts a little.

GWEN (CONT'D)
That's not mine. It was theirs -- they left it behind. I was wondering... if it was causing all this. Somehow. I don't know...

She trails off, resigning to the fact there's still no other explanation here. Peter stretches the weighty silence.

PETER
Let me ask you something: Did you honestly think this was gonna work?
(clarifying)
All of it. The cave. Me getting better. Because you seemed surprised when it did. Maybe even -- disappointed.

Long beat. He gestures to the mug...

PETER (CONT'D)
So is that the plan now? Poison me? Move on with your life, like you were expecting to be able to by now?

Gwen leans in, a tinge of venom.

GWEN
Why would I bother poisoning you -- when I can just leave you here?

Peter bristles at the threat.

PETER
This was your idea. Remember that.

GWEN
You never let me forget it.

PETER
A fairytale. That's how you described this place when we first got here. Imagine that.

Gwen boils over in the ensuing silence. Defiantly gulps down the tea. Slams the empty mug on the table. Nothing happens.

Peter is unrepentant, his animosity unyielding.

PETER (CONT'D)
I'm stuck here because of you.

GWEN
I was trying to help!

PETER
Yourself!

GWEN
How does any of this help me?!

PETER
You dragged me all the way out here, when I could've been doing more trials instead.

GWEN
You did them! They didn't work!

PETER
I should've done more! But instead, you insisted we check this box, too.
(the headline)
This was all so you wouldn't feel guilty this time.

GWEN
That's not true.

PETER
So that, when I died, you could tell yourself you tried everything.

GWEN
(mask slipping)
That's not...

PETER
I watched you do it for years! Torturing yourself, blaming yourself, running through every little thing you did that might've caused you to lose the baby. One day it was because you didn't get enough, fucking whatever, vitamin E -- or, for getting too much of it;

the next day it was the flu vaccine you convinced yourself you should've never gotten; then, it was how you read somewhere that microwaves are dangerous and, oh God, there was that time you stood too close to ours for, like, five seconds. And on and on and on. The blame. And the guilt.

GWEN
You mean when you barely did anything to make me feel like I shouldn't feel that way? You watched me go through it? No you didn't; you didn't watch anything. You barely gave a shit. I needed you, and where were you?

PETER
I was there.

GWEN
Barely. The hardest thing in my life, and where were you, Peter? Gone. Checked-out. Because you couldn't deal with it. So you left me to, alone.
(fighting back tears)
How could you have been so... selfish?

PETER
Because I didn't think it was mine.
(off Gwen's surprise)
That's right.

Gwen seems poised to respond, but doesn't.

PETER (CONT'D)
You don't think I knew about you and what's his face -- the guy you worked with? And you think I don't know what's going on now?

GWEN
Nothing's going on.

Peter subtly-but-pointedly references her bandaged hand.

PETER
You didn't do that alone.

A tense beat. *

PETER (CONT'D) *
You didn't want to live with guilt again. That's why we're here, not because you actually expected this to work. So, don't you dare fucking tell me this was for me. Don't you dare -- call me selfish.

Gwen's gaze falls downcast. Unable to refute much of that.

Long, silent beat.

Peter aggressively pushes back his chair, startling Gwen. He storms out of the kitchen. Gwen follows him into --

101 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS 101

Peter makes a beeline for the laptop --

GWEN
What're you--?

-- and SMASHES it against the stone hearth.

GWEN (CONT'D)
What the hell are you doing?!

PETER
The fairytale's over. Nothing's gonna magically fall from the sky and fix things.

Next, he rips up the photo of Inga/Anna and Jon --

PETER (CONT'D)
So stop trying to track people down...

-- and then tosses the field guide into the fireplace.

PETER (CONT'D)
No more sneaking off, no more trying to find out what's going on, 'cause I'll tell you. You ready? This is our house now. This is your life now. Here. With me. Forever.
(beat)
That's the plan.

He lets his words hang heavy before marching out of the room.

Gwen tends to the shambles. Cut down to size. Piecing together the ripped photo.

CUT TO:

102 EXT. CAVE - NIGHT 102

A particularly windy night. The craggy mountain cast in blue-gray moonlight. The cave's mouth open in permanent darkness.

103 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - SAME 103

Peter sleeps alone. His chest slowly rising and falling. He twitches a little. Dreaming fitfully.

An UNKNOWN P.O.V. watches him closely in bed. Studying him. Threateningly close.

The P.O.V. then lowers, gliding downward... past the underside of the bed... and continuing right through the floor --

104 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS 104

-- and then emerging from the living room ceiling. Finding Gwen in an OVERHEAD VIEW, lying on the couch.

A thin blanket doing little to keep her warm. Her eyes weighted, allowing only intermittent spates of slumber.

As the P.O.V. moves closer to her... now within inches...

Gwen awakens with a sharp, indrawn breath, but unsure why. She steadies herself, unnerved. The house is silent, save for the yowling wind and the fire crackling in the hearth.

105 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - MOMENTS LATER 105

Gwen slowly opens the door. Peeks inside, sees Peter asleep. A beat, then she closes the door.

106 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER 106

Dark. The clock ticks. Gwen slowly steps inside. Click. She turns on the light.

The room seems eerily still. Like it's holding its breath.

As she remains by the doorway, confounded, a cold chill climbing her spine...

...a faint squeaking sound comes into relief from the living room. She turns around, that chill running even colder.

106A INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - SECONDS LATER 106A

Gwen returns to where she was, until only moments ago, asleep on the couch. Only to discover, in the dark corner, sits a --

BABY CARRIAGE. An old pram-style version. Its wheels squeaking. Swaying slightly, as if something is inside.

Gwen swallows hard, already trembling.

A beat, then she steps closer... closer... now seeing a cursive-written letter "J" embroidered on the pram's side.

The faint coos of a newborn baby are heard emanating from it.

When her view crests into the pram, her heart melts. There's a NEWBORN GIRL inside, tucked under a knitted blanket.

GWEN
Oh... Okay, it's okay... I'm here...

She gently scoops the baby and its blanket into her arms. Gwen's whole body trembling now, reeling as she holds the blanket-ensconced baby to her chest.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Oh, my baby. My sweet, sweet girl. My sweet, sweet baby. My sweet, sweet...
(something's wrong)
...girl.

Looking down, folding back the blanket in her arms...

GWEN (CONT'D)
No... No-no-no-no...

...Gwen finds the blanket empty. The baby is gone.

Gwen is reduced to rubble. Shaken to the core. A thick, single tear crawls slowly down her cheek.

Then... she gently folds the blanket... and places it back into the pram. Numb. And so very close to broken.

A long beat, then she turns to walk away--BUT EINAR'S TOWERING METALWORKS HULDUFOLK IS RIGHT THERE AND GRABS HER!!

SMASH TO:

107 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - SAME 107

Gwen awakens with a start, gripping the couch. The fire crackles in the hearth. The wind blows outside.

Terror abating, she rubs at her teary eyes, her temples. Her senses connect with a squeaking sound -- quite similar to that of the pram's squeaky wheels. It's coming from outside.

108 EXT. FARMHOUSE - MOMENTS LATER 108

The front door opens. Gwen cautiously steps outside. An ectoplasmic AURORA BOREALIS paints the sky.

She sees that the wheelchair, long ago discarded and folded-up against the house, has been toppled by the wind.

One of its wheels still slowly spins from the fall, causing the squeaking sound. It finally stops.

She uprights the wheelchair. Gwen makes a puzzling discovery. Something she only now ever fully appreciated...

There, affixed to the back of the wheelchair, is the laminated plastic pocket that she earlier noticed. The small notecard remains in it.

Removing the card, Gwen sees the following typed on it:

"EIENDOM TIL ANDERS SYKEHJEM - BERGEN, NORGE" *

With the name *"HELENE HAUGEN"* handwritten just below. *

The discovery fuels a restart of her mental gears.

109 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER 109

Gwen opens the damaged laptop. Its screen is cracked, some keys are missing, but it's still operable.

She plugs the landline phone cord into it. The dial-up connects. It's not exactly quiet, much to her concern.

110 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - SAME 110

The dial-up can faintly be made out. Peter reacts subtly in his sleep, coming close to rousing... but ultimately doesn't.

111 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER 111

Gwen has connected to Google Translate. She keys in what appears, in typeface, on the notecard:

"EIENDOM TIL ANDERS SYKEHJEM - BERGEN, NORGE" *

-- and receives the following translation:

"PROPERTY OF ANDERS NURSING HOME - BERGEN, NORWAY" *

She scribbles this translation on the notecard, then circles:

"BERGEN, NORWAY" *

JUMP TO -- Working the computer again. This time Googling the name typewritten on the index card:

"HELENE HAUGEN" *

And then adding *"BERGEN, NORWAY"* to the search. *

To her dismay, the results are somewhat scattershot. So, she changes tacks --

She retrieves the now-taped-back-together photo featuring a younger Inga/Anna and Jon.

Scrawled on the back of that photo, as was earlier revealed, are the names: "ANNA & JON"

Now combining information: *"ANNA + HAUGEN + BERGEN, NORWAY"* A beat, then she presses ENTER. *

<u>Pay dirt.</u> A link to a Norwegian newspaper. *

Double-click. It's an archived 2015 article from a local publication in Bergen, Norway.

The photograph associated with the article features Anna.

Much younger than when we met her. Seated amongst other professional colleagues, podium microphones before them.

Gwen clicks a button -- featuring the American flag -- switching the website text to English.

Doing so, however, initiates a video POP-UP. A local advertisement JINGLE rings out through the laptop's speakers.

Gwen hastily tries to silence it.

112 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - SAME 112

The faintly heard song is enough to begin to awaken Peter. But, Gwen's evidently found a way to silence it.

113 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - SAME 113

Gwen lifts her finger after pressing the MUTE button. Waits. Listens for movement from upstairs...

She hears nothing. Gets back to her investigation. The article's headline is what first captures her attention:

"COUNCILWOMAN STEPS DOWN" *

The photo caption beneath it confirms the woman to be:

"ANNA HAUGEN-LARSEN, CITY COUNCILOR - LABOUR PARTY." *

Gwen's eyes fly down the screen. Poring over the information:

"...lifelong resident of Bergen, and fifth-year member of the *
city council..." *

"...temporarily closed her small business..." *

"...relinquished her council seat to focus on caring for her *
sick elderly mother." *

Hmmmm... *

Gwen reconsiders something she just read: *"her business"* *

She clicks back to the Google Search. Types:

"BERGEN, NORWAY + BUSINESS DIRECTORY" *

She clicks on the first search return, a link to the equivalent of a Secretary of State's business database.

She types "ANNA HAUGEN-LARSEN" into the website's KEYWORD search bar. Her breath catches when it returns:

Firmanavn: "Birch Kafé" *

Innehaver: "Anna Haugen-Larsen" *

Adresse: Årstadveien 24, Bergen *

Telefon: 54 96 58 00 *

GWEN
(sotto)
I've got you.

CUT TO:

114 EXT. FARMHOUSE - MORNING 114

Existing in stillness. Drab and nearly colorless in the lean winter sun.

The front door quietly opens. Dressed in a thick sweater and heavy coat, Gwen slips outside.

115 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - SAME 115

Peter is still asleep, alone in bed.

The sound of the front door closing is faintly heard. Then, through the window, CAMERA FINDS Gwen as she furtively absconds, heading toward the road.

CAMERA then REVERSES, revealing Peter is now awake.

116 EXT. ROAD - MORNING 116

Gwen hurries along this lonely stretch, finally coming upon Einar's house. His small boat still trailered out front.

PRE-LAP: *Knock-knock-knock!* *

117 EXT. EINAR'S STUDIO - MOMENTS LATER 117

Gwen waits at the door. Glancing over her shoulder.

To her surprise, Einar does not answer. Instead, an unfamiliar woman does. This is KATLA, Einar's wife. Striking even in her rumpled sleepwear and confused countenance.

KATLA
Hvernig get ég aðstoðað?

GWEN
Oh. I, um --

Einar arrives behind Katla, rubbing the sleep from his eyes. Surprised to see Gwen at the door.

EINAR

Gwen.

GWEN
I need to use your phone. Please.
(relief and triumph)
I found her.

Katla looks at Einar. A terse exchange in Icelandic, then she then disappears back inside.

EINAR
(to Gwen)
Come in.

118 INT. EINAR'S STUDIO - MOMENTS LATER 118

Gwen has a landline phone pressed to her ear, waiting for someone to answer her placed call. A pleasant-sounding NORWEGIAN WOMAN finally does --

NORWEGIAN WOMAN (V.O.)
Hallo. Birch kafé. *

Gwen refers to the info she jotted down on the notecard.

GWEN
I'm looking for Anna. Anna Haugen-Larsen.

NORWEGIAN WOMAN (V.O.)
Yes, she is the owner.

GWEN
I need to speak with her. It's very important.

NORWEGIAN WOMAN (V.O.)
Hold, please.

The din from inside the cafe is heard on the other end.

As Gwen waits, getting anxious, she glances over to the next room where, through a half-open door, she sees Einar quietly arguing with Katla.

ANNA (V.O.)
Dette er Anna.

Gwen is momentarily dumbstruck upon hearing this voice.

ANNA (V.O.)
Hallo...?

GWEN
It's you.

ANNA (V.O.)
Who is this, please?

GWEN
You know who it is.

Anna's breath catches.

GWEN (CONT'D)
What did you do?
(off Anna's silence)
Answer me.

ANNA (V.O.)
I -- I do not know what you're--

GWEN
Yes you do.

ANNA (V.O.)
You have the wrong number, I'm (sorry).

GWEN
(over)
What did you do to us? What did you do?!

Katla glares from the next room. Reacting to Gwen's shouting.

ANNA (V.O.)
I have to hang up. --

GWEN
-- No, please, no -- I need to know what's happening.

ANNA (V.O.)
Please do not call here again.

GWEN
How do we make it stop? Please --

ANNA (V.O.)
-- I'm sorry. --

GWEN
Please!

ANNA (V.O.)
-- I have to go.

GWEN
-- No, wait --

ANNA (V.O.)
-- I'm sorry. --

GWEN
No-no, wait, don't hang up --

Click. Anna abruptly ends the call. Gwen immediately dials the number again.

It rings twice, but it's obvious that Anna picked up and then immediately hung up the phone.

Desperate, Gwen dials again -- only this time to be met with a busy signal. Click. She tries again -- still busy.

Overcome, Gwen breaks down in sobs, her visage warping with despair. Einar tactfully approaches...

EINAR
Are you...?

Gwen collapses onto him, seeking support.

Unsure at first how to respond, Einar gradually reciprocates. Gwen burrows into his shoulder, bawling.

KATLA
Einar?

He shrugs, acknowledging the awkwardness. Katla, displeased, flounces out of the room when there's a KNOCK at the door.

CAMERA STAYS here with Gwen and Einar. Gwen pulls herself together, ashamed of her display.

GWEN
I'm sorry.

Rising commotion is heard from elsewhere in the attached residence. It's Katla; her voice increasingly turns to panic.

EINAR
Katla?

Second later, Peter storms into the studio, undeterred by Katla's scared, Icelandic protestations.

He stops, sees Gwen and Einar still in remnants of embrace.

PETER *
Let's go. Now.

GWEN
I came here to use the phone.

PETER
I said, let's go!

GWEN
I found her! Listen to-- I found Inga!

PETER
Now!!

Peter GRABS onto Gwen. Starts DRAGGING her.

GWEN
Get off me!

EINAR
Hey!

GWEN
Let go of--!

She fights back, but Peter's too strong. Keeps dragging her.

CHAOS erupting. Messy, brutal. Knocking against and toppling Einar's metalwork projects -- including the metal Huldufolk.

KATLA
(in Icelandic)
Stop that! Stop!

Einar GRABS Peter. Tries to PULL him away from Gwen.

But -- Peter turns the tables. SLAMS Einar against the wall.

KATLA (CONT'D)
Einar!

Katla screams out panicked pleas in Icelandic.

Peter swipes past her. Catches sight of Gwen as she hurries out of the studio. Stalks after her.

PETER
Gwen!!

119 EXT. EINAR'S STUDIO - SECONDS LATER 119

Peter emerges outside. Breathing heavy. Seething.

He sees Gwen, now a distance up the road, fleeing.
Disappearing into a thick, recently-settled FOG.

Just as Peter starts after her --

-- Einar bursts outside and TACKLES him to the snowy ground. The two men WRESTLE. Ugly, real violence.

Katla appears at the doorway. Terrified.

KATLA
Einar!

Peter gains the upper hand. Ends up atop Einar. *SMACK!* PUNCHES him square in the face. Blood spills. *

JONAS
Papa! Papa!

Einar and Katla's young son, Jonas, has also arrived in the door. Still wearing his pajamas.

SMACK! Peter PUNCHES Einar again. *

JONAS (CONT'D)
Papa!!

Hearing young Jonas, Peter stops. The boy's pleas having broken through his madness. He releases Einar's collar, lets him slump to the crimson-stained snowy ground.

Katla and Jonas rush to Einar's side. Peter watches them, horrified. He regards the blood on his knuckles. A reckoning.

PETER
...I'm sorry.

A beat, then he leaves them behind, trailing after Gwen.

120 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - MORNING 120

Gwen frantically packs a few belongings into a bag. Takes all their cash stored in a bureau drawer. Finds her passport.

Steals a quick look out the window -- no sign of Peter. She * exits the bedroom and hurries down the stairs. Tears open the * front door and escapes.

UNKNOWN P.O.V.: Watching her as she races away down the driveway. Her small bag in tow as she makes for the road.

121 OMIT 121

122 OMIT 122

123 OMIT 123

CUT BACK TO:

124 EXT. ROAD - MORNING 124

Peter runs down the foggy road. Searching for Gwen.

125 EXT. DOCK - MORNING 125

A small crew of FISHERMEN untie their trawler from the dock, about to set out for a day's labor.

GWEN (O.S.)
Wait! Wait-wait-wait!

They see Gwen running down the dock. Frantic.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Please, let me go with you.

The Fishermen exchange perplexed looks.

GWEN (CONT'D)
I can pay you. Can you bring me across the channel?

She peels off about a third of the full wad of cash.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Please. I'm begging you.

After a quick exchange between the fisherman, they agree. Gwen hands him the money. Climbs onboard. One of the other fisherman finishes untying the vessel.

126 EXT. ROAD - MOMENTS LATER 126

Grunting breaths, still on the run, Peter notices people aboard a fishing trawler. Down by the dock.

Stopping and looking closer, he realizes one of them is Gwen.

127 EXT. FISHING TRAWLER - SAME 127

The last of the ropes are pulled up. They can't leave soon enough, as far as Gwen is concerned.

PETER (O.S.)
Gwen! Wait!

Her eyes widen when she sees Peter racing down the dock.

PETER (CONT'D)
Wait!

The Fisherman at the wheel looks to Gwen, unsure what to do.

GWEN
No, no -- don't stop.

Peter tracks alongside the trawler as it glides up toward the last lengths of the dock.

PETER
Please. Don't do this. Don't leave me here.

Gwen watches him as the boat continues to pull away. Unable to ignore the change in his manner. Genuine remorse.

PETER (CONT'D)
I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. Please, Gwen. Don't go. Please.

But he's reached the end of the line. In a final plea...

PETER (CONT'D)
I can't live without you.

He and Gwen hold each other's gaze as the trawler slips further and further away.

128 EXT. PORT - REYKJAVIK, ICELAND - DAY 128

Having just disembarked, Gwen navigates through this busy harbor. Replete with locals and tourists alike.

128A EXT. BUSY STREET - MOMENTS LATER 128A

En route to a well-trafficked intersection, Gwen removes her cellphone from her pocket. Sees that it finally has service.

Scrolling, she finds the CUSTOMER SERVICE number for an airline. Calls it. *

129 EXT. CITY SQUARE - MOMENTS LATER 129

One of Reykjavik's central terminals for CITY BUSES and AIRPORT COACHES.

An airport coach is about to depart. Gwen hurries over to stop it, tapping the glass, her cellphone pressed to her ear.

GWEN
Please, wait-wait.

The coach doors hiss open. Gwen climbs onboard.

129A INT. AIRPORT SHUTTLE - SECONDS LATER 129A

PASSENGERS with luggage in tow. Gwen proceeds down the aisle.

Takes a seat near the back as the bus leaves the terminal.

She texts her sister, Sara, as she meanwhile waits on hold with an airline (evidenced by the on-hold music and redundant *"Thank you for holding...* etc." voice recording). *

GWEN: "CAN YOU PICK ME UP AT LOGAN TONIGHT?"

SARA: "FINALLY COMING HOME???"

GWEN: "YES. ON WAY TO AIRPORT NOW. TRYING TO BOOK FLIGHT."

SARA: "PETER TOO?"

Gwen sighs.

Another call comes in. She doesn't recognize the number, so she silences it, remains on hold.

The AIRLINE AGENT returns to the call --

AIRLINE AGENT (V.O.)
Thanks for holding. Are you there?

GWEN
Sorry, yeah.

AIRLINE AGENT (V.O.)
Alright, so here's what I have...

Gwen rifles through her pockets for something to write on, finding the now-familiar notecard.

AIRLINE AGENT (V.O.)
Okay, so the only U.S.-bound flight left today out of Reykjavik leaves at 8:45pm tonight.

GWEN
Going to Boston?

AIRLINE AGENT (V.O.)
Yes, nonstop to Boston-Logan Airport.

Gwen jots down this information on it.

AIRLINE AGENT (V.O.)
Would you like me to go ahead and book it?

Gwen's given pause when she regards other information she previously wrote on this same notecard:

"Anna Haugen-Larsen" *

"Herlig Kafé" *

"Årstadveien 24, Bergen" *

AIRLINE AGENT (V.O.)
Ma'am?

Gwen's torn. Turning everything over in her head. Until --

GWEN
Um, can-- Do you mind checking if you have any flights to Norway?

AIRLINE AGENT (V.O.)
Norway Norway?

GWEN
Yes, um, Bergen, Norway.

AIRLINE AGENT (V.O.)
Returning to Reykjavik?

GWEN
No. Still to Boston.

AIRLINE AGENT (V.O.)
Lemme see... We have two, actually. Both would get you there before 4:00PM, local time, today. Would you like me to book you one of those flights instead?

HOLD ON Gwen in this moment, debating.

CUT TO:

130 INT. CAFE - BERGEN, NORWAY - NIGHT 130

Rain soaks the windows of Birch Kafé. *

The last CUSTOMER of the day completes a takeaway transaction with the proprietor, Anna (A.K.A. Inga). Her gaunt, haunted look is gone. Seemingly at home in her return to this life.

ANNA
Nyt. Takk skal du ha.

The door jingles as the Customer exits with their purchase.

Anna starts to close up shop for the day. Turns off a few lights, shuts off the music.

She then rounds a corner, wraps a sheet of pastry in plastic wrap. As she does, she hears the front door jingle again.

ANNA (CONT'D)
(calling out)
Beklager, vi har stengt.

But when she receives no reply -- nor does she hear the door jingle again -- she stops what she's doing to check on why.

ANNA (CONT'D)
Vi åpner igjen kl--

Anna stops in her tracks, stunned to silence -- because Gwen is there. Soaking wet, laced with anger.

ANNA (CONT'D)
You shouldn't be here.

GWEN
If you had taken my calls, I wouldn't be.

ANNA
That's not-- You shouldn't--

Anna is too overwhelmed to continue. She needs a moment. Instead, she fumbles with shop-closing tasks, her movements jerky and unfocused, avoiding Gwen's eyes.

Heavy silence between them at first.

GWEN
What is it?
(brass tacks)
Is it a curse?

Anna stops momentarily, drifting into darkly unforgettable memories, unsure how to properly answer the question.

ANNA
It is... punishing. The Huldufolk make sure of that. Day and night. They find... your rawest nerve -- and they press on it.

(beat)
Of course, you know that by now.

GWEN
What are they punishing us for? We didn't do anything.

ANNA
You accepted their gift.

GWEN
Peter's health?

Anna nods sparely. Still struggling to be part of this.

ANNA
Those who accept it prove their selfishness. Those who refuse, are spared. Like you, we learned all of that too late.

GWEN
But not how to get around it.

At that, Gwen places down a piece of paper. Anna recognizes it as the "PLEASE FORGIVE US" note she wrote.

ANNA
We tried -- for so long. To resist passing it to someone else, just as it had been passed to us. But...
(can't continue)
I'm so sorry.

GWEN
You trapped us there.

ANNA
To finally free ourselves. It is the only way.

GWEN
There has to be another way to end it.

ANNA
I could only ever think of one. And I can't tell you how many dark times we considered it.

Gwen notices an empty teacup there on the uncleared table, seeming to connect some mental dots for her.

GWEN
The blue flowers. The tea.

ANNA
(brooding nod)
It seemed... a peaceful means. Thankfully, it never came to that.

GWEN
(anger rising again)
Yeah. Thankfully.

ANNA
I don't expect it to provide you comfort, but there has not been a moment I haven't thought of what I did to you and your husband. I live with the guilt of that choice every day.

GWEN
In your quaint little cafe.

ANNA
My mother and I barely speak anymore. My husband filed for divorce two months after we returned. There's no happy ending in any of this.

Anna wipes away the tears pearling in her eyes. Sighs acquiescently.

ANNA (CONT'D)
I'll tell you whatever you want to know.

131 OMIT 131

132 OMIT 132

133 EXT. CAFE - EVENING 133

The rain has subsided, though the city remains wet and gray. A few DENIZENS pass by the cafe windows.

Gwen and Anna are seen inside, still seated at a cafe table.

134 INT. CAFE - SAME 134

We join as Anna unspools the thread of her experience...

ANNA
...She kept getting sicker and sicker, no matter what we tried. Apart from my husband, my mother was my world. I could not lose her.
(beat)
I'd researched all kinds of treatments after the standard ones failed. I learned of the cave from a letter I received; a man, claiming to be a healer, had somehow learned of my mother's illness. He offered -- an alternative. And I took it. Against my mother's wishes, I brought her there. My husband as well. Selfishly.

GWEN
It worked for her.

ANNA
By now you know at what cost.

Gwen's phone vibrates against the table. She checks the display, doesn't recognize the number. Silences it.

ANNA (CONT'D)
I expected we'd be there for a day. Two, at most. I even brought my computer, thinking I could catch up on some work.
(beat)
We were there for over ten years.

GWEN
It was your mother who was sick, right? Not your husband's.

ANNA
Yes.

GWEN
But he still stayed?

ANNA
There was one time he left, very early on.

Gwen's phone rings again. It's again from the unfamiliar number. This time, Anna sees the number on the display.

ANNA (CONT'D)
You should answer.

GWEN
I don't know who it is.

ANNA
That is the house number.

Gwen briefly considers answering, but doesn't.

GWEN
I wanna know why your husband came back.

ANNA
If you answer, you'll understand.

Gwen silences the call.

ANNA (CONT'D)
Then you will when you return.

GWEN
I'm not going back. I'm going home.

Anna straightens with distress.

ANNA
No, you must.

GWEN
You're in no position to tell me --

ANNA
-- No, please, listen --

GWEN
-- what I should be doing. --

ANNA
-- You don't understand. He needs--

GWEN
I'm not here for what he needs. I'm here because--

Changing gears to better explain her position, Gwen stabs her finger at Anna's "PLEASE FORGIVE US" note --

GWEN (CONT'D)
You wrote this in Norwegian for a reason.

ANNA
I wrote it in haste.

GWEN
Bullshit. You could've just as easily written it in English.
(explaining her theory)
You didn't want us to know what it said; you just wanted to be able to tell yourself you left it. If we couldn't read it, that's on us. But you -- you did your part; you said you were sorry. You even left us...
(refers to teacup)
...a peaceful way out. You did everything you could. For yourself.
(now for the truth)
And I know that because I'm here...
(ashamed)
...so I can know I did everything I could, too.

This lands hard. Both women take a turn toward reticence.

Gwen's cellphone vibrate-rings. Both women glimpse the display and see that Peter is calling again. *

GWEN (CONT'D)
I want this all to stop for him. Now that I know how it can, I'll call and tell him. But, I can't go back there. I won't.

Gwen sends the call to voicemail. Her certainty solidifies in the ensuing silence.

ANNA
We are the choices we make.

At that, Anna rises from the table and heads behind the counter, leaving Gwen alone.

135 EXT. CAFE - MOMENTS LATER 135

The door jingles when Gwen exits. A cold, grim wetness coats the vacant city streets.

As she crosses the road, she receives a text message from the airline, prompting her to check in for her flight to Boston, departing in two hours.

She's about to click "CHECK IN" when her cellphone rings yet again with a call from Peter.

After brief debate, Gwen stops and finally answers --

GWEN
Leave me alone.

She's met by faint, pained grunts on the other end.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Peter?

PETER (V.O.)
...Gwen...

The weakness in his voice arrests her. Each breath is more labored than the last, each word requiring colossal effort.

GWEN
Yeah, what are you -- ?

PETER (V.O.)
You... have... to come back.

GWEN
No -- I'm-- I told you --

Gwen glances across the street, at the cafe, where she sees Anna watching her through the glass door.

PETER (V.O.)
Please! ...Please. Hur-- hurry.
It's... it's you too.

A knowing look on her face, Anna locks the door, turns the sign to "CLOSED" before disappearing inside.

PETER (V.O.)
You can't leave either.

The revelation grips Gwen.

The CHECK-IN button remains on her phone screen -- the end of her nightmare just a click away; Peter's dying breaths in her ear, begging for her return.

HOLD ON Gwen, fraught with indecision. Faced with a dilemma very much of her own making.

CUT TO:

135A EXT. CAVE - DAWN 135A

Orange-yellow stings of sunlight inch the cave out of darkness.

136 OMIT 136

137 OMIT 137

138 OMIT 138

139 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - DAWN 139

CLOSE ON the landline phone. BLOOD smeared on it. Separated from its cradle, emitting a “howler tone” (the sound of a landline phone that’s off the hook).

WIDER VIEW shows the desk is overturned, the couch askew. Various items spilled and in disarray.

The front door is partly open. Outside it, WE SEE Gwen appearing from far down the driveway. Hurrying toward the house in a frantic search for --

GWEN
Peter?! Peter?!

-- until her eyes catch on something near the barn.

GWEN (CONT’D)
No-no-no-no-no.

She scrambles in that direction. Her heart sinking.

140 EXT. BARN - SECONDS LATER 140

Peter lies face-down on the ground. Gwen rushes to him. Shakes his rag-doll frame, trying to rouse him. She removes her coat, wraps it around him.

GWEN
Ohmygod-ohmygod, Peter. Peter!

A faint moan crosses his ashen, dried-blood-stained lips.

GWEN (CONT'D)
Peter. I'm here, I'm here.

His crusty eyes open and find hers.

Relief washing over Gwen, she nevertheless can't ward off grim contemplations about what it means to be back there.

GWEN (CONT'D)
...I'm here.

FADE TO:

141 OMIT 141

142 INT. FARMHOUSE - DINING ROOM - MORNING 142

Gwen and Peter sit across from each other. A blanket draped across his shoulders, his face mostly washed of dried blood.

PETER
My body has gotten healthier here, but my mind...
(wide open)
I'm so sorry. For everything.

He struggles to meet her gaze, the shame heavy.

GWEN
I came really close to not coming back. You need to know that.

PETER
I would've understood if you hadn't.

GWEN
You would've been dead if I hadn't.

He nods, humbled and contrite.

PETER
What I've become -- it's not who I am. It's who -- it's who they've made me. But it's my fault for letting them.

GWEN
You've seen them, too.

He nods slowly. Gwen appraises him. Vindicated.

PETER
I won't let them again. I'll never hurt you again. Ever.

Gwen quietly takes him in. A long beat...

Then she reaches into her purse and removes a small plastic shopping bag -- an airplane logo on it and the generic name of a sundry store located at the Bergen airport.

PETER (CONT'D)
Did you buy me a souvenir?

His small smile fades when his joke doesn't even register -- and Gwen's inscrutable expression crumbles.

PETER (CONT'D)
What?

A long beat.

GWEN
It wasn't yours.

Peter looks at her, unsure what she means.

GWEN (CONT'D)
The baby.

The clarification stills him. Gwen reframes the statement; not to hedge, but to for the sake of total transparency.

GWEN (CONT'D)
There's a chance it wasn't. An equal chance.

A deep, wounded surprise that lingers. The air between them thick with a new, raw honesty.

PETER
Why are you telling...?

GWEN
Because I should've a long time ago. Because I'm sorry, too.

The shattering truth taking time to process.

GWEN (CONT'D)
I came very, very close to not coming back.
(beat)

GWEN (CONT'D)
So I decided... if I were to, it couldn't only be to heal you.

A beat, then she reaches into the plastic bag. Peter watches, unsure what she's doing or intimating. That is, until she removes the bag's contents: three boxes of PREGNANCY TESTS.

PETER
Gwen...

GWEN
You got your time back. But I'm running out of mine. *

PETER
It's not-- We'd be bringing a baby into this.

Gwen shakes her head.

GWEN
Not if we left.

PETER
We can't leave. That's the problem.

GWEN
I found her.
(clarifying)
Inga. Anna.

Peter's face flashes with surprise.

PETER
What'd she say?

GWEN
That there's a way that we can.

The relief this brings Peter is tempered by Gwen's bewildering apprehension. He correctly senses there's a rub.

143 EXT. FARMHOUSE - MOMENTS LATER 143

Peter stands just outside the front door. His heavy, conscience-stricken sighs frost in the morning cold.

A moment later, Gwen joins him outside.

PETER
I don't know if I can do it. To put someone else through this...

GWEN
Neither do I.

Peter's conflicted gaze lands on the folded-up wheelchair.

PETER
How long were they trapped here?

GWEN
Over ten years.

He looks at her, struck by this. Daunted as well.

GWEN (CONT'D)
We can't live like this for that long, Peter.

PETER
Or longer.

Gwen nods, restraining her tears.

GWEN
Then we have to decide.

They look at each other, the strength and seriousness of this allegiance being gauged...

CUT TO:

144 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER 144

CLOSE ON the landline phone cord plugging into the laptop.

WIDER VIEW shows Gwen opening the laptop. Peter beside her. They together pull up an alternative therapies WEB FORUM, with which Gwen is clearly familiar. *

There, on the webpage's masthead, in cheesy font, is the recognizable refrain:

"GIVE PROMISE YOUR BELIEF, AND YOU SHALL BE GIVEN PROMISE OF YOUR HEALTH." *

Below this are hundreds and hundreds of entries bearing such dubious thread titles as:

- *"ANYBODY DO CUPPING FOR HIP ARTHRITIS?"* *
- *"THIS WORKS!!! YOU SEE EFFECTS IN 6 DAYS"* *
- *"CRYSTAL HEALING THERAPY - OPEN DISCUSSION"* *

- *"BIG PHARMA ANXIETY MEDS SCAM"* *

Gwen signs in and they begin their self-serving outreach to desperate people in desperate need. *

She and Peter find each other's hands.

145 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - NIGHT 145

Peter and Gwen embrace. Kissing. Touching. Discreet lovemaking.

UNKNOWN P.O.V.: Watching from beyond the ajar bedroom door.

FADE TO BLACK.

146 EXT. CAVE - MORNING 146

The landscape still bears winter's scars, as if refusing to yield the lushness springtime should bring. *

BEGIN MONTAGE: *

147 INT. FARMHOUSE - BATHROOM - DAY (MONTAGE) 147 *

An iPhone TIMER counts down to zero. Its ALARM sounds.

A moment later, Gwen arrives. She shuts it off -- then picks up the at-home PREGNANCY TEST from atop the counter. A weary sigh. *

It is NEGATIVE.

She tosses it into the trash, adding to a growing pile of used tests.

148 INT. FARMHOUSE - UPSTAIRS HALLWAY - MOMENTS LATER (MONTAGE) *

Peter sees Gwen as she exits the bathroom. His question dies unasked as her face answers it for him.

149 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT (MONTAGE) 149 *

UNKNOWN P.O.V.: Watching Peter from the shadows as he sits at the open laptop. Its monochromatic glow on his face.

He reviews the message board website. Frustration and deepening despair.

SEE that their post has thus far received: "0 REPLIES"

150 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - NIGHT (MONTAGE) 150 *

Gwen and Peter finish having sex. It seems rote, prescriptive.

They both roll over. Still in this together, but slipping into resignation. The glint of hope fading.

151 EXT. FARMHOUSE - DAY (MONTAGE) 151 *

CHOP! An AXE splits a piece of firewood. *

It's winter. Again. Snow falls. Peter stacks the wood atop a noticeably paltry pile.

He stills when, out of the blurry corner of his vision, he sees someone standing there -- wearing a yellow parka. The Huldufolk further testing him, pressing that nerve, endeavoring to drive him back to that dark place.

He resists -- but it takes effort. A sense his defenses are abrading. He places another log on the chopping block. Peering that way again, the parka-wearing figure is gone.

152 EXT. FARMHOUSE - GARDEN - SAME (MONTAGE) 152 *

Gwen shivers against the cold. Appreciable physical decline. Unable to source anything from this frozen, barren land.

She comes upon a small patch of the poisonous blue-petal flowers. As she regards them, the heart-rending cries of a baby rise within the howling wind.

The distressed, desperate pleas invade deeper into her psyche. She closes her eyes, willing it to stop but failing.

153 INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT (MONTAGE) 153 *

Peter adds a log to the fire glowing weakly in the hearth.

Gwen sits at the laptop, open to the message board webpage. * Peter tacitly inquires if anyone's finally replied -- to which Gwen responds with a melancholy shake of her head.

154 EXT. SHORELINE - DAY (MONTAGE) 154 *

Gwen stands by the water's edge, nothingness behind her eyes, watching the waves roll in and out. Hanging on by a thread.

She's too numb to even be fazed when, at least from her *
perspective, the waves momentarily begin to flow backwards.

155 INT. FARMHOUSE - DAY (MONTAGE) 155 *

Gwen's iPhone timer alarm is ringing and seemingly has been. Peter and Gwen are sprawled on the floor; he holds her in her profound sadness.

His own sorrow a palpable weight upon him. Another NEGATIVE pregnancy test. Very few tests remaining.

The agonizing realization this isn't working -- and likely won't ever.

156 EXT. CAVE - NIGHT (MONTAGE) 156 *

Shrouded in darkness. A hopeless void. *

END MONTAGE *

CUT TO:

157 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - NIGHT 157

The wind howls outside. The home's insulation-free construction offers minimal respite from the cold.

Buried beneath several tattered blankets, Gwen and Peter sleep fitfully. The room drowning in shadows.

Gwen's eyes flutter open when, from across the room, she faintly hears a musical lullaby.

Her breath hitches when she looks over and sees...

...a SOUND MACHINE on the dresser. It plays the lullaby, while its PROJECTOR casts a cartoon image onto the ceiling.

The sound machine cycles to a new song... then the sound of lapping waves... then settles on a FETAL ECHO HEARTBEAT.

Thump-thump... thump-thump... thump-thump... *

GWEN
Peter. Wake up. Wake up.

He rouses slowly at first, then straightens when he registers what's occurring.

Thump-thump... thump-thump... thump-thump... thum-- *

It abruptly stops. The projected image goes dark.

But its intended effect remains. Gwen's ever closer to breaking.

In the ensuing silence...

...the bedroom door s-l-o-w-l-y creaks open. They both slowly turn to face it. Staring expectantly into the void.

The door comes to a stop, a quarter of the way open.

They're paralyzed. Fearing what might emerge.

An eternal, thousand-pound silence.....

RIIIIIIING!! .... RIIIIIING!! *

Coming from the phone downstairs. Creating a dilemma.

PETER
We need to answer that.

GWEN
Don't go out there, Peter.

PETER
They could be calling about coming here. We need to answer.

The phone continues ringing, resonating through the house. Their tense gazes linger on the darkness at the door.

Then the phone stops ringing from downstairs, to his chagrin.

An agonizing beat. Thick with fear.

Just then, in the hollowness, a FOOTSTEP is heard, thudding onto the bottom step... then the next.... and the next...

THUD... THUD... THUD... *

Slowly climbing the stairs.

Gwen and Peter reel in fear. Frozen. Staring at the door.

THUD... THUD... *

THUD. *

It reaches the top. A Huldufolk. Draped in dripping-black darkness.

Peter and Gwen can faintly make out its frighteningly large, lanky frame in the void.

An excruciatingly long beat...

...and then the Huldufolk slowly turns and, based on the sound of its heavy footfalls, enters the adjacent bedroom.

Peter eyes the door. Its lock. He builds the nerve.

Slowly, he starts climbing from bed.

GWEN
(whisper)
Peter?

His feet quietly touch the floor, just by the sinister underside of the bed.

He stands. His feet leadened with fear as he starts toward the door, his eyes fixed into the torturous darkness.

Closer... closer..... Almost there..... Reaching.....

He springs forward -- slams the door shut -- locks it.

Releasing the tense breath, his heart hammering, he slowly backs away from the door, his eyes never leaving it.

Gwen joins alongside him, eyes trained on the door as well. As if expecting it to be bashed off the hinges at any moment.

But not yet. Not yet. Still nothing. Still.... nothi-- The sound machine clicks back on and squeals FEEDBACK, intensely loud, just as --

SEVERAL HULDUFOLK CONVERGE FROM OUT OF THE ROOM'S SHADOWS!!

SMASH TO:

158 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - SAME 158

Gwen and Peter both LEAP UP from bed at the same time. Disoriented and terrified.

Breathless, they look at each other, seeming to know they both just experienced the same nightmare.

A very deep sigh as Peter's still coming down. Gwen drapes her arms around him. Both of them failing to meet the demands of this intolerable existence.

Boiling over, Peter leaps up. Screams out, spittle flying --

PETER
Enough! Enough!! En--

Midway through his last "enough," because it's abundantly clear by now they have no agency, no say in the matter, we --

CUT TO:

159 EXT. FARMHOUSE - GARDEN - DAY 159

Gwen's face is pallid and gaunt. Clothes hang despairingly from her winnowed frame. There's barely anything left to her.

Pacing through a thin mist, she trudges over the mucky soil, scarcely able to find anything worth picking.

160 EXT. BARN - SAME 160

Peter chops a piece of firewood. Reaches for the next one -- only to discover... there isn't any more.

He lets the axe slip from his grasp. Purposeless. Defeated.

161 EXT. FARMHOUSE - GARDEN - LATER 161

Carrying back to the house a pitiable yield of vegetables, Gwen stops when she once again hears a crying baby. Her weary eyes close.

She doesn't want to hear it. It's all too much to take.

The crying finally fades away... as the sound of cawing birds rise in the soundscape.

She looks skyward, watches as a few ravens circle above.

But the birds' flightpaths seem disrupted. Now taking jagged, inelegant turns in the sky.

Looking further afield, Gwen sees a patch of the poisonous blue flowers. A raven noshes on their petals, then flies off.

Just then, a different raven seems to lose its motor skills -- then dive-bombs straight down onto the distant road, head-first, disappearing into where a low-lying FOG has settled. *

Gwen considers the flowers once again, making the connection.

162 EXT. ROAD - MOMENTS LATER 162

Gwen steps out onto the gauzy, fog-smothered road.

Walking closer, she starts to make out the ravens up ahead. All but one is dead on the ground, its wing twitching.

Gwen watches. Affected, but too numb to evince just how much.

After a few more nearly imperceptible flaps of its wing, the moribund raven's body stops moving altogether.

Gwen stares at it with a tragically blank expression.

LITTLE GIRL (O.S.)
Is it dead, Mommy?

Turning around, Gwen is stunned to silence. There, standing in the road, amidst the fog... is a five-year-old GIRL.

Gwen doesn't know who she is. And yet, she does.

GWEN
Joy?

The Girl stares back. Silent. But then turns and hurries off into the fog. Gwen follows after her --

GWEN (CONT'D)
No, wait. Wait!

-- but the little Girl is gone. Gwen stands there, gutted.

After a beat, Gwen finally turns to walk away--

BEEEEEEEEEEEEEEP!!! A speeding taxi smashes right into her. *

SMASH TO:

163 INT. FARMHOUSE - BATHROOM - DAY 163

Gwen's eyes open, her head lifting from her chin, finding her reflection in the mirror. Her face wan and weary.

There she stands, an unresolved pregnancy test in hand, awaiting a result as her iPhone counts down. Minutes to go.

The test slips from her limp grasp, clattering to the floor. She turns off the iPhone timer well before it has finished.

That's it. It's over. She's finally broken.

164 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - LATER 164

Gwen is seated at the table. Her lachrymose gaze lifts when Peter arrives in the doorway, looking just as beleaguered.

PETER
I think... you should go.

GWEN
I'm not leaving without you.

PETER
Then I don't know how else this ever ends.

Long beat on Gwen, regretfully deciding...

GWEN
I do.

165 INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER 165

CLOSE ON a mug being filled with steaming water.

WIDER VIEW shows Gwen then filling a mug for herself as well. The tea tin on the table. The ground-down petals in the mugs.

Peter and Gwen, seated at the table, both gaze at their mugs. Resolved, but still trepidatious.

PETER
Will it hurt?

GWEN
She said it would be peaceful.

PETER
I don't know if I trust her.

GWEN
Then trust me.

A beat.

PETER
I do.

She looks at him. He means it.

PETER (CONT'D)
I'm scared.

She nods. She's scared too.

Their foreheads touch. Tears fall.

PETER (CONT'D)
I love you.

GWEN
I love you too.

The time has finally come. Both take their mugs in hand...

Slowly raise them closer to their lips...

There's no trickery at play here; no "you-go-first"-type efforts at outwitting each other.

Put simply, this is the end.

But, just before the tea crosses their lips...

...a faint sound is heard outside. And whatever it is, it's getting louder -- and closer.

Their mugs lower in bewilderment, neither having taken a sip.

The entire house begins to QUAKE as POWERFUL WINDS press down upon it from above.

Gwen and Peter rise from the table and cross to the window, confounded by the sight before them...

A sightseeing tour HELICOPTER lowers from the sky, onto the property. Its rotors, already decelerating, flatten a broad swath of grass as it lowers out of view behind a RIDGE.

166 EXT. FARMHOUSE - MOMENTS LATER 166

Gwen and Peter open the front door and exit. Nonplussed.

A sightseeing tour HELICOPTER has landed on the property, but remains out of view behind the ridge.

Its Icelandic PILOT rounds the ridge, coming into view down the driveway. He offers a courtesy wave to Gwen and Peter before waving over to someone unseen behind the ridge.

A moment later, a middle-aged Japanese man and his Japanese wife emerge.

KENSHI AOKI, (45), approaches Gwen and Peter. He looks worn down. Desperate. Someone who, at least in recent times, has only known hardship. *

Alongside him is his wife, HIMARI AOKI, (42), reticent and overburdened. Kenshi physically assists her. *

KENSHI AOKI *
(accented English)
The ferry was not available for several hours.

The two couples meet halfway. Some distance kept.

KENSHI AOKI (CONT'D) *
Have we come to the right place?
(clarifying)
You and I messaged briefly, many months ago, on the message board. I am Kenshi Aoki. This is my wife. Himari.

Gwen and Peter realize what this might be about.

GWEN
...Right.
(assuming the role)
Right, yes.

KENSHI AOKI *
Oh, thank you. Hello. Thank you.

Kenshi excitedly shakes their hands. But Himari is wan. *
Frail.

KENSHI AOKI (CONT'D) *
We thought she was getting better. For a time, she was. But...

Himari utters something in Japanese.

KENSHI AOKI (CONT'D) *
She said, thank you for seeing us.

GWEN
Of course.

HIMARI AOKI
(accented English)
Thank you.

KENSHI AOKI *
We are very desperate to help her. Please. We have tried everything.

Gwen nods, doing her best to contain her swelling emotions.

GWEN
Do you mind -- giving us a moment?

KENSHI AOKI *
But you will help her, yes? Please.

GWEN
Yes. We will. Just -- one second.

Gwen and Peter turn to walk back inside.

167 INT. FARMHOUSE - SECONDS LATER 167

They close the door behind them. Immense relief washes over them as they hold each other tightly.

GWEN
Is this happening? Is this really...?

PETER
Yes.

Emotions roil. But, they have to pull it together -- and quickly. Gwen swats away her relieved tears.

GWEN
Oh my god. Oh my god, Peter. We're gonna get out of here.

They glance outside and notice Kenshi walking back toward the * ridge, though Himari remains outside the house.

PETER
Where's he going?

GWEN
(disregarding it)
I don't know, but, okay, alright. We can do this. We can do this.
(creeping doubt)
...Right

For the first time since Kenshi and Himari's arrival, Gwen * and Peter seem to be having second thoughts.

PETER
...Yeah.

So they grasp for justification.

PETER (CONT'D)
I mean, her not dying is what they want, so -- it's worth it, worth the, the tradeoff for them.

Gwen suddenly seems off as she searches her memory.

GWEN
...Right.

PETER
What?

GWEN
...I don't -- think she is, though.

PETER
You don't think she's what?

GWEN
If I'm remembering right, in his messages, he didn't say she was-- *
(reframing it) *
She has Chron's Disease.

PETER
Is that terminal?

GWEN
No.

PETER
Are you sure?

GWEN
Sara's had it since she was twelve.

Long beat. Both suddenly suffering reservations.

PETER
Are we still doing this?

HOLD ON Gwen and Peter as they stand at the crossroads...

168 EXT. FARMHOUSE - MOMENTS LATER 168

CLOSE ON a wheelchair as it unfolds open. WIDER sees Peter latching it and readying it for use.

He and Gwen stand before Himari Aoki, committing to the pseudo-shamanistic role. Kenshi has yet to return.

GWEN
That path continues to a cave. That's where you'll find the healing water. Soak in it. Give promise your belief, and you shall be given promise of your health.

Himari seems to mostly understand. She nods a hopeful, teary-eyed nod.

Peter gestures for Himari to sit on the wheelchair.

PETER
Go ahead.

But to their confusion, Himari does not sit. She just looks at them. Her eyes still glistening with hopeful tears.

Then, after a long beat, she slowly turns and looks down the driveway. Unsure why, Gwen and Peter look as well.

And that's when Gwen's face sinks with horror, because... Rounding the ridge, walking hand-in-hand with Kenshi, is a * LITTLE GIRL.

She's all of six years old, at most. And patently unwell.

With her father's help, the little girl, EMIKO, hobbles over, soon arriving alongside her mother.

Finally aware of what's actually happening here, Gwen and Peter are thunderstruck.

KENSHI AOKI *
It has become very difficult for her. The treatments that have helped others did not help her. We had almost given up hope.
(tearing up)
Thank you.

HIMARI AOKI
(thick accent)
Thank you. Thank you.

Gwen and Peter are absolutely gutted when Kenshi and Himari * help Emiko into the wheelchair. So small her feet dangle.

KENSHI AOKI
Okay. We are ready.

Gwen and Peter are shell-shocked. Barely able to muster...

GWEN
No.

KENSHI AOKI *
No?

GWEN
...No. This-- I'm sorry. We can't do this.

KENSHI AOKI *
What? No, we are here. --

GWEN
-- I know, but--

KENSHI AOKI *
No, no, we are here. Please.

Kenshi starts to push the wheelchair, but Peter puts a hand on it to stop it. Unable to look them in the eye. *

KENSHI AOKI (CONT'D) *
What are-- Let go --

GWEN
--No, please. You need to go home.

KENSHI AOKI *
Please. Our daughter, Emiko -- she is very sick.

GWEN
I understand. But, but -- we can't--

Himari and Kenshi speak in Japanese. Panicking, scared this is slipping away from them. *

KENSHI AOKI *
(to Gwen)
You said -- in your messages -- you said it can cure her.

Gwen regards the young girl. Her struggles are written on her like a record, but so too is her preciousness.

GWEN
I didn't-- I didn't realize you meant-- We can't do this to you.
(long beat)
Please forgive us.

A benumbing beat of finality... then Gwen and Peter turn and walk back toward the farmhouse.

Stunned to silence, Kenshi and Himari watch them go. *

169 INT. FARMHOUSE - MOMENTS LATER 169

Gwen and Peter stand at the door, watching through its windows as the Aoki family paces back toward the helicopter.

Himari stops, Emiko held in her arms, and takes one last look at Gwen and Peter... and then rounds the ridge.

169A INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - MOMENTS LATER 169A

Outside WE SEE grasses bending as the propeller spins, whipping wind across the sprawling grounds and snapping clothes on the clothesline.

The helicopter lifts off and then disappears back up into the sky and over the mountains.

170 INT. FARMHOUSE - DINING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER 170

The filled tea mugs remain on the table. Gwen clears and throws both of them away. Then, the tea tin as well.

171 INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - NIGHT 171

Gwen and Peter lie down to sleep. They look into each other's eyes. Mutually assured they made the moral choice, but nevertheless aware of its ramifications for them.

In time, and with surprising ease, they both drift off.

FADE TO:

172 EXT. CAVE - MORNING 172

Arcs of light flourish the cold morning sky, brightening the edging around the cave's entrance.

173 INT. FARMHOUSE - MORNING 173

Gwen awakens unhurried and uncommonly rested. As she lies there for a moment...

...she hears COUGHING coming from somewhere.

GWEN
Peter?

She receives no reply. Hears the coughing once again.

Growing somewhat worried, she pulls back the blankets and climbs from bed.

174 INT. FARMHOUSE - BATHROOM - MOMENTS LATER 174

Gwen sets foot slowly into the room, her face already drawing down with confusion, because...

...Peter is shearing off his hair.

But most striking of all is that he appears unwell -- sick like he was when they first arrived at the island, including the burgeoning reappearance of the lesions on his neck.

He wipes his face, coughing briefly. He turns and looks at Gwen, allowing her to take in the version of him with whom he, himself, has apparently only begun to reacquaint.

GWEN
You're...?

PETER
Sick. Dying. Again.

He smiles ruefully.

PETER (CONT'D)
And that's okay.

They take each other into shared embrace.

PETER (CONT'D)
Let's go home.

She looks at him, questioning this, but Peter assuages her with an assured nod.

The hold each other tighter, confounded by this turn of events, but enjoying comfort they've both long forgotten.

175 EXT. FERRY - MORNING 175

Gwen and Peter board the ferry, neither receiving any particular notice from the crew.

They make toward the bow of the ship. Peter's gait is a bit unsteady, requiring some help -- which Gwen provides.

Bellying-up to the railing, Gwen is first to notice a small boat nearby. Peter looks as well, seeing Einar onboard it along with his wife, Katla, and their young son.

Even from this distance, Peter's transformed and ill-seeming appearance does not go unnoticed, disarming Einar.

In a final act of contrition, Peter extends an olive-branch wave -- which Einar returns in kind.

The ferry's engine grinds to life, the ropes are pulled from the dock.

176 EXT. FERRY - MOMENTS LATER 176

The ferry crosses the CHANNEL. The sea is calm, visibility is clear. Gwen and Peter stand at the bow, staring ahead.

As the island disappears further and further behind, and the mainland appears in the distance, Peter remains unharmed.

His hand finds hers. She rests her head on his shoulder. Both of them grateful to begin the final chapter of their story together.

176A INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MORNING 176A

A silent, vacant room. The faint tick of the clock is all that's heard.

176B INT. FARMHOUSE - LIVING ROOM - MORNING 176B

The hearth lies cold, dormant. Throw blankets neatly folded in a pile. The room is still.

176C INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM - MORNING 176C

Also empty. The bed neatly made. The curtains drawn open.

177 INT. FARMHOUSE - BATHROOM - MORNING 177

Taking in the rays of sunshine outside...

...and then LOWERING toward the floor... seeing Peter's hair clippings scattered on the tile...

...and finally SETTLING ON the pregnancy test that had just yesterday clattered to the floor, unread.

It has produced a result: POSITIVE

HOLD ON this image as we...

FADE OUT.

THE END *